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2 dead, 23 injured as sleeper bus overturns in Karol Bagh



NATION: Pg 6

Nityanand Rai introduces FCRA Amendment Bill in LS



FILM: Pg 12

'I've always believed in high-quality work'

Iran rejects US ceasefire plan, says it will end the war on its own terms

The US plan reportedly includes sanctions relief, nuclear rollback, missile limits and Hormuz reopening

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran on Wednesday dismissed an American plan to pause the war in the Middle East and launched more attacks on Israel and Gulf Arab countries, including an assault that sparked a huge fire at Kuwait International Airport. Iran's defiance came as Israel launched airstrikes on Tehran and Washington deployed paratroopers and more Marines to the region. Iranian state television's English-language broadcaster, Press TV, quoted an anonymous official as saying Iran rejected America's ceasefire proposal. Press TV's report came after Pakistan transmitted the proposal to Iran. "Iran will end the war when it decides to do so and when its own conditions are met," Press



First responders inspect the remains of a residential building hit in an overnight strike during the U.S.-Israeli military campaign in Tabriz, East Azerbaijan Province, northwestern Iran, on Tuesday

TV quoted the official as saying. The official added Tehran will continue its "heavy blows"

across the Mideast.

Al Jazeera news network, quoting a high-ranking dip-

lomatic source in Tehran, said that Iran described the US proposal as "extremely maximalist

IRAN'S CONDITIONS TO END THE WAR

- » Immediate halt to US and Israeli attacks on Iran and its allies
- » Guarantees to prevent any future war against Iran
- » Financial reparations for damage caused during the conflict
- » Formal end to hostilities across the region

RECOGNITION OF IRAN'S SOVEREIGNTY OVER THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

and unreasonable." "It is not beautiful even on paper," the

New CAPF Bill to regulate recruitment, promotion, deputation

NEW DELHI: An "umbrella law" introduced by the Union government on Wednesday for Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) will regulate recruitment, deputation, promotion, and other conditions of service for their officers. All CAPFs - CRPF, CISE, BSF, ITBP and SSB - are governed by their respective Acts.

ALL-PARTY MEET

PM told Trump to end war, India not 'dalaal' nation like Pak: Govt

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India cannot act as a "dalal (broker) nation like Pakistan" in global geopolitics, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar was quoted as having told an all-party meeting on the West Asia crisis on Wednesday, as the Opposition raised concerns over Pakistan's role in mediating talks between the United States and Iran.

The government told an up-in-arms Opposition at the meeting that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has conveyed to US President Donald Trump that the war in West Asia must end soon as it is hurting everyone.

There is nothing new in Pakistan's mediation efforts in the matter as that country has been "used" by the US since 1981, sources quoted S Jaishankar as saying at the all party meeting. "We are not a dalaal nation," Jaishankar is said to have told the participants at the meeting convened at the Parliament complex to discuss the West Asia crisis.

The sources added that the government refuted the Opposition's charge that New Delhi was silent on the situation, asserting that "we are commenting and responding".

When the Iran embassy was opened, the Foreign Secretary visited immediately and signed the condolence book, the government told the parties in response to



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Congress MPs Mukul Wasnik and Tariq Anwar, Samajwadi Party (SP) MP Dharmendra Yadav and others leave after the all-party meeting convened by the government to discuss the ongoing West Asia crisis, in New Delhi, on Wednesday

TAKEAWAYS

- » Opposition flagged Pakistan mediating US-Iran talks, questioned India's role
- » Govt says PM Narendra Modi urged Donald Trump to end war soon
- » Jaishankar said US has "used" Pakistan for mediation since 1981
- » Govt dismissed Opposition claims of silence, said India is responding actively
- » Foreign Secretary visited Iran embassy, signed condolence book promptly
- » Govt prioritising Indian diaspora safety and domestic energy security
- » ASSURED SUFFICIENT OIL STOCKS, IMPORTS DIVERSIFIED ACROSS 41 COUNTRIES

the Opposition's charge that India displayed moral weak-

ness in not condoling the death of the Iranian Supreme Leader sooner.

The government is also said to have informed the parties that its prime concern is ensuring the security of the Indian diaspora living in the Gulf region and fulfilling domestic energy needs. On that count, the government said it has been successful so far.

The Opposition, however, said the answers provided at the meeting by the government were "unsatisfactory" and demanded that a debate be held on the West Asia situation in both Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha.

Lashing out at the government, Congress's Tariq Anwar said Pakistan is performing the mediator's role while "we are still mute spectators". He said there should be a debate on the situation in Lok Sabha under rule 193 and in Rajya Sabha under rule 176.

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In today's paper

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Congress faces eviction from historic Akbar Road, Raisina Road offices

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: In a move that could trigger a political confrontation, the government has issued final notices to the Congress party to vacate its offices at 24, Akbar Road and 5, Raisina Road in Lutyens' Delhi by March 28, party sources said.

The Akbar Road bungalow, which has served as the Congress headquarters for about 48 years since 1978, continues to host core party activities despite the inauguration of a new headquarters, Indira Bhawan at Kotla Marg, last year. The Raisina Road premises house the Indian Youth Congress.

According to sources, the notices were delivered only a few days ago, giving the party less than a week to respond. Leaders described the timeline as sudden, with internal discussions underway on the next course of action.

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QS WORLD UNIVERSITY RANKINGS BY SUBJECT

Four IITs, JNU, BITS Pilani among world's top 50

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India's higher education institutions have secured a stronger global footing, with four Indian Institutes of Technology, Jawaharlal Nehru University and BITS Pilani featuring among the top 50 worldwide in specific subjects, according to the latest QS World University Rankings by Subject released on Wednesday.

The rankings, compiled by London-based QS Quacquarelli Symonds, mark their 16th edition and assess more than 21,000 academic programmes across 1,900 universities in over 100 countries. These evaluations span 55 disciplines grouped under five broad faculty areas.

India has recorded 27 entries within the global top 50 across subjects and faculty

TAKEAWAYS

- » QS releases 16th edition ranking 21,000+ programmes across 1,900 universities
- » India secures 27 top-50 spots in 2025, up from 12 in 2024
- » 12 Indian institutions contribute to the country's top-50 rankings
- » ISM Dhanbad ranks 21st in Mineral and Mining Engineering
- » IIM Ahmedabad ranks 21st in Business, Management and Marketing



- » India enters global Marketing rankings for the first time
- » IIT Bombay, Kharagpur and Madras among top performers

areas this year, a sharp rise from 12 in 2024. These positions have been secured by 12 institutions, indicating a wider distribution of high-performing programmes.

Among individual per-

formers, the Indian School of Mines University, Dhanbad, achieved a global rank of 21 in Mineral and Mining Engineering. IIM Ahmedabad also secured the 21st position in both Business

Continued on P4

Govt writes to states to reserve 20% jobs for Agniveers

MPOST BUREAU

HAMIRPUR (HP): Union Home Minister Amit Shah has urged all states to reserve 20 per cent of government jobs for Agniveers after they complete their four-year tenure in 2027, an official said on Wednesday.

The communication, addressed to chief ministers, was confirmed by Brigadier Madan Sheel Sharma (Retd), director of the Sainik Welfare Department. After receiving the letter, the Himachal Pradesh Sainik Welfare Department forwarded a report to the state government for consideration.

The proposal covers roles including forest guards, mining guards, police constables, firemen, mounted police personnel, jail

Continued on P4

GET YOUR CKYC NUMBER, IT HELPS IN OPENING ACCOUNT AND RE-KYC

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SWIFT RESCUE BY POLICE, LOCALS PREVENTS HIGHER TOLL

2 dead, 23 injured as sleeper bus overturns in Karol Bagh

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Two male passengers died and 23 others were injured in a horrific late-night accident in Central Delhi's Karol Bagh area, where a tourist sleeper bus overturned near Hanuman Mandir in the early hours of Wednesday, triggering a dramatic rescue operation led by alert police personnel and locals.

Police were alerted to the accident through a PCR call received at Karol Bagh Police Station.

According to police, the incident occurred around 1:05 am on March 25, when a PCR call informed the Karol Bagh Police Station about the overturned bus near Chambery.

Within minutes, chaos unfolded at the scene as passengers trapped inside the mangled vehicle cried out for help in the darkness.

The bus, en route from Jaipur to Fatehpuri in Sadar Bazar, was carrying around 30 passengers despite having a capacity of nearly 70.

Eyewitnesses described scenes of panic and desperation, with injured passengers



Damaged remains of a sleeper bus after it overturned near Hanuman Mandir, in Karol Bagh area, New Delhi, on Wednesday

struggling to escape as the bus lay on its side.

Acting swiftly, the Station House Officer of Karol Bagh, along with link picket staff and night patrolling constables, rushed to the spot and immediately launched rescue efforts.

In a display of quick thinking, Constable Rohit halted a passing JCB machine, which proved crucial in stabilising the overturned bus.

With the help of public volunteers, police carefully lifted the vehicle slightly and secured it using heavy cement blocks,

allowing rescuers to access those trapped inside.

The risky operation, carried out under pressure and in the dead of night, helped prevent further casualties.

Approximately 10 critically injured passengers were initially pulled out and rushed to Sir Ganga Ram Hospital.

As reinforcements arrived, including senior officers and additional police teams, the rescue operation intensified.

Women and children were among those extracted from the wreckage in what officials

TAKEAWAYS

» Acting swiftly, the Station House Officer of Karol Bagh, along with link picket staff and night patrolling constables, rushed to the spot and immediately launched rescue efforts

» In a display of quick thinking, Constable Rohit halted a passing JCB machine, which proved crucial in stabilising the overturned bus

described as a coordinated and life-saving effort.

In total, 23 injured persons were evacuated and shifted to different hospitals across the city. Twelve were taken to RML Hospital, where two male victims succumbed to their injuries, while 10 others were admitted to Sir Ganga Ram Hospital and one to Lady Hardinge Medical College.

The deceased have been identified as Sheh-baj Alam (30), a resident of Bijnor in Uttar Pradesh, and Mahesh (22).

The bus driver, Pankaj Kumar (26), a resident of Alwar in Rajasthan, has been detained and is currently undergoing treatment for injuries sustained in the crash.

Police have registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and initiated a detailed investigation into the circumstances leading to the accident.

Officials said preliminary findings are being corroborated with statements from injured passengers and on-ground evidence.

Investigating officer SI Trilok is collecting medical reports and eyewitness accounts as part of the probe.

The bodies of the deceased have undergone post-mortem at RML Hospital and are being handed over to their families, while several injured passengers remain under treatment. Authorities are also compiling details of those discharged or shifted to other facilities.

Police officials credited the timely response, coordination and assistance from the public with saving numerous lives in what could have been an even greater tragedy.

Police bust cross-border arms smuggling module

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police on Wednesday said they have busted an arms smuggling module with links to Pakistan, Nepal and Bangladesh, and arrested 10 people.

A cache of sophisticated foreign-made weapons, including sub-machine guns and automatic pistols, along with 200 live cartridges, has been recovered from the accused, they said.

According to police, a total of 21 firearms were seized during the operation, comprising high-end automatic weapons and pistols sourced from multiple countries.

Among the recovered weapons are a Czech Republic-made sub-machine gun and



a range of pistols of different international makes.

The seized arms include PX-5.7 pistols, which are generally used by special forces, Stoeger pistols manufactured in Turkey, PX-3 pistols from China, Shadow CZ pistols from the Czech Republic, as well as Beretta (Italy), Taurus (Brazil) and Walther (Germany) pistols, officials said.

Preliminary investigation

revealed that the module was part of a well-organised cross-border network involved in smuggling and supplying illegal arms to criminal elements in India, they said.

The accused were allegedly in touch with international handlers and suppliers operating from neighbouring countries, the police said. The syndicate used covert routes and intermediaries to transport weapons across borders and further distribute them to contacts in different parts of the country, they added.

The police said efforts are underway to trace the backward and forward linkages of the module and identify other associates involved in the network. Further investigation is underway.

Burglary in Hari Ngr house; jewellery, cash looted

NEW DELHI: A house in west Delhi's Hari Nagar area was burgled while the occupants had gone out for a temple visit, with gold and silver jewellery along with cash worth several lakhs stolen, police said on Wednesday.

The incident was reported after the complainant, Rishabh Khanna (28), of Virender Nagar, returned home with his family on Tuesday evening

to find the main gate lock broken and the house ransacked.

Khanna told police that the family had gone to Jhande Wali Temple for darshan earlier in the day. Upon their return, they discovered that valuables had been stolen from the premises. During verification, gold jewellery weighing about 40 tolas, silver articles weighing approximately 3.5 kg and cash of about Rs 4 lakh

were found missing, a senior police officer said. A case has been registered, and an investigation has been taken up.

CCTV footage showed an unidentified person arriving on a scooter with a fake number plate, entering the house masked and gloved, and committing the burglary swiftly. He later handed the stolen items to an associate before both fled.

AGENCIES

7-year-old witnesses father shoot mother and friend in Gzb; 38-year-old on the run

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A seven-year-old boy is believed to have witnessed the fatal shooting of his mother and his father's close friend inside their home in Tronica City's Rampark Colony, police said. Though his formal statement is yet to be recorded, officers said the child told them that his father, Rashid (38), took out a gun from an almirah in the bedroom around midnight and opened fire.

According to police, the minor recounted that Rashid first shot his friend Faheem (32), a long-time associate at his furniture shop, and then turned the weapon on his wife, Shabnam (36). The child had reportedly been watching television when he heard raised voices and walked into the room, only to witness the shooting.

After the incident, Rashid allegedly turned to his son and said, "ab sab thik ho jayega" (now everything will be fine), before leaving the house. Police said the child's account is crucial to the investigation, and efforts are underway to formally record his statement in accordance with legal procedures. Police said the incident stemmed from a suspected extramarital relationship between Shabnam and Faheem that had allegedly been ongoing for over two years. Investigators said Rashid had recently come to know about the relationship and was distressed, as his wife was reportedly planning to leave him.



“ Rashid had already concealed a pistol inside the house, indicating possible premeditation ”

On Monday evening, Rashid allegedly invited Faheem to his house for dinner. The three ate together and later smoked before a heated argument broke out. Police suspect Rashid had already concealed a pistol inside the house, indicating possible pre-

meditation. During the altercation, he allegedly used the weapon to shoot both victims at close range.

DCP (Rural) Surendra Nath Tiwari said both Shabnam and Faheem sustained gunshot wounds to the head and were declared dead after neighbours rushed them to a hospital.

Their bodies have been sent for post-mortem, and reports are awaited. An FIR has been registered against Rashid under Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita on a complaint filed by Faheem's father.

Police teams have been formed to trace the accused, who is currently absconding. Efforts are also being made to recover the weapon used in the crime and determine how and

when it was procured.

Investigators further revealed that both Rashid and Faheem had prior criminal records. Faheem had multiple cases registered against him, including attempt to murder, theft and violations of the Arms Act, while Rashid had earlier been arrested in a theft case in 2023.

The couple had been married for several years and had seven children aged between 1.5 and 20 years. Police said tensions in the household had escalated in recent months, particularly after Rashid learned about the alleged relationship around the time of their eldest son's wedding six months ago.

Despite his objections and repeated requests to end the relationship, the dispute reportedly continued.

Officials said Rashid and Faheem had argued a week earlier. Shabnam was considering divorce and planning to sell the house in her name, a factor that may have further escalated tensions leading up to the double murder.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police's Crime Branch has busted two illegal LPG hoarding and black-marketing rackets in separate operations in South Delhi and Dwarka districts, seizing more than 240 gas cylinders and booking five accused persons.

According to police, in the first operation, the Crime Branch's Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF) conducted coordinated raids at multiple rented godowns in the Sangam Vihar area and recovered 183 Indane LPG cylinders, including 154 filled and 29 empty ones.

Police also seized equipment used for illegal refilling, including iron pipes, iron pokers and electronic weighing machines.

Four delivery agents associated with an authorised LPG distributorship were found involved in the illegal operation and were bound down in the case.

They were identified as Sher Singh (35), Suraj Parihar (36), Raghu Raj Singh (53) and



Jitender Sharma (39), all residents of Sangam Vihar.

The operation followed specific intelligence inputs suggesting that LPG cylinders meant for household distribution were being hoarded and illegally refilled at rented premises in the area.

Acting on the information, a dedicated Crime Branch team conducted raids at three locations in L-Block of Sangam Vihar, where the accused were found actively engaged in the illegal activity.

During interrogation, investigators learnt that the accused, registered LPG delivery personnel of an authorised Indane gas agency with its main storage facility in Sheikh

Sarai, would deliberately withhold cylinders from their daily delivery quotas.

These cylinders were secretly stored at rented godowns, where the accused illegally transferred LPG from filled cylinders into empty ones using iron pipes.

Police said the accused typically extracted around one to two kilograms of gas from each cylinder and refilled empty cylinders up to permissible levels.

The refilled cylinders were then sold in the open market at prices higher than the prescribed rates, allowing the accused to make illegal profits while exploiting public concerns over a potential LPG shortage.

In a separate crackdown on illegal LPG trade, a joint team of the Anti-Auto Theft Squad (AATS) of Dwarka district and the staff of Chhawla Police Station raided a residential premises in Kashmiri Colony on Paprawat Road in Chhawla.

Police seized 65 LPG cylinders, arrested Ashok Kumar; cases filed under law, probe ongoing, strict action assured.

News at a glance

DMRC-NSD COLLABORATION TO PROMOTE ARTS

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation has signed an MoU with the National School of Drama to promote theatre, cultural awareness and creative engagement among employees and commuters, with programmes, workshops and outreach activities planned across metro premises.

AISA SLAMS TRANSGENDER RIGHTS BILL AS REGRESSIVE

NEW DELHI: The All India Students' Association has condemned the passage of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha, terming it regressive and harmful to transgender rights. In a statement, AISA alleged the Bill undermines self-identification upheld in the NALSA judgment and increases state control over gender identity. It also criticised weak penal provisions and demanded rollback, along with stronger safeguards including reservation and welfare measures for the community.

DELHI UNIV ANNOUNCES 65 FACULTY POSTS

NEW DELHI: University of Delhi has announced recruitment for 65 faculty posts across departments including Botany, Commerce, Economics, English and Psychology. Positions include Professors, Associate and Assistant Professors. Candidates must meet academic criteria, with a PhD required for senior roles. Applications are online, with April 6, 2026 as the deadline.

Hoax bomb threats sent to 17 Noida schools

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: At least 17 schools in Gautam Budh Nagar district received alleged bomb threat emails on Tuesday morning, triggering a swift response from security agencies. Officials later confirmed that all the threats were hoaxes, and an investigation has been launched to trace the sender.

According to police, around 14 schools in Noida received the emails on their official IDs between 4 am and 5 am. Acting on alerts from

school authorities, teams from the bomb squad, dog squad and anti-sabotage check (ASC) units were deployed to conduct thorough inspections of the premises. No suspicious objects were found during the searches.

Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police (Noida) Manisha Singh said precautionary measures were taken to ensure the safety of students and staff. Several schools remained closed, while checks at those that were operational were carried out carefully to

avoid panic. The cybercrime unit has been tasked with analysing the emails and tracing their origin.

In Central Noida, three schools reported similar threats, but searches yielded no alarming findings. No such emails were reported from Greater Noida, police said.

Officials added that no FIR has been registered yet, though inquiries are ongoing. They also noted that a similar incident on February 19, involving 18 schools, remains under investigation.

Uttam Ngr violence: SC asks petitioners to approach Delhi police commissioner

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked petitioners seeking safety and security for the family members of 26-year-old Tarun Butolia killed in a clash in Delhi's Uttam Nagar on Holi to approach the Delhi police commissioner.

On March 4, Tarun died after being injured in a clash between two neighbouring families. The altercation was triggered after a water balloon thrown by a girl from one



community accidentally hit a woman from the other.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, while declining a CBI

probe in the matter, said that if the issue was ineffectively addressed by the city police, the petitioners could approach the Delhi High Court.

"The petitioners have sought certain directions with respect to an unfortunate incident of March 4, 2026, resulting in the untimely death of a young individual..."

"...We find that some of the directions sought are essentially administrative issues regarding the safety and security

of individuals for the victim's family," the bench said.

Underlining that the city police could examine the issues, the bench granted them the liberty to submit a "comprehensive representation" to the police commissioner. Court said police will assess threat and take steps; petitioners may approach Delhi High Court. CJI urged trust in Delhi Police. Violence earlier led to protests, arson; multiple accused have been arrested.

AGENCIES

3 more arrested in Pak-linked espionage racket

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GHAZIABAD: Police have arrested three more alleged members of a Pakistan-linked espionage racket accused of sending sensitive information across the border, taking the total number of arrests in the case to 21, including six minors, an official said.

Among those held is Sameer alias Shooter, a native of Bhagalpur in Bihar and currently residing in Delhi, who is believed to be a key operative in the network. The other two accused are Sameer from Shamli district and Shivraj from Shahjahanpur, now residing in Ghaziabad.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Trans Hindon) Dhawal Jaswal said the National Investigation Agency has interrogated the accused, and a charge sheet has been filed in a Ghaziabad court. Police said the racket was allegedly operated from Pakistan by a handler identified as Sardar alias Zoravar Singh. The group is accused of collecting and transmitting photos and videos of security installations, police units and railway stations.

Investigators said the network in India was run by Suhel Malik alias Romeo, who allegedly recruited members and paid around Rs 5,000 per input, routing funds through intermediaries to avoid detection.

House goes full throttle: ‘Sheesh Mahal’ row, walkout, bomb scare

Speaker flags hoax RDX bomb threats; mails sent to police, probe ordered

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Legislative Assembly on Wednesday witnessed high-voltage proceedings marked by sharp political exchanges, detailed allegations over the ‘Sheesh Mahal’ controversy, discussions on the Budget 2026–27, a condemnation motion on Punjab, Opposition boycott, and security concerns following hoax bomb threats.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta tabled a detailed account in the House alleging serious financial irregularities in the construction of former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal’s official residence, popularly referred to as the ‘Sheesh Mahal.’ Calling the CAG findings a ‘document of moral decline,’ she said the issue reflected a ‘well-planned deception’ and not merely expenditure on infrastructure. At her request, the report was referred to the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) for a detailed probe.

Striking a combative tone, Gupta said Kejriwal ‘saw himself as the ‘Shahanshah-e-Alam,’ treating people as subjects. Quoting a couplet, she remarked, ‘‘Wo zahar deta to sabki nigah mein aa jaata... usne yoon kiya ki dava dena band kar diya.’’ She questioned the contrast between claims of simplicity and alleged extravagance, pointing out that while Kejriwal once criticised Sheila Dikshit for having 10 ACs, his residence allegedly had ‘‘50 ACs and 70 fans.’’

She further alleged that the project cost escalated from Rs 8 crore to Rs 62 crore and included luxury features such as a lift for transporting food, premium refrigerators, imported coffee machines and engagement of six private consultants for interiors, furniture and landscaping. Raising the COVID



context, she said construction continued while people were suffering. She also listed expenditure on residences of other politicians, alleging misuse of public funds, including Rs 7.5 crore on Manish Sisodia’s residence, Rs 2.33 crore on Rakhi Birla’s, Rs 3.23 crore by Ram Niwas Goel, Rs 2.55 crore by Gopal Rai, Rs 2 crore by Satyendar Jain, Rs 3 crore each by Imran Hussain and Rajendra Pal Gautam, and Rs 1 crore by Saurabh Bhargava.

Joining the attack, Minister Parvash Sahib Singh delivered an extensive speech, saying, ‘‘I kept saving my home from termites, but a few worms of power devoured the entire city.’’ He alleged that within 20 days of assuming office, a bungalow was allotted, calling it a betrayal of promises. Referring to the pandemic, he said, ‘‘When Delhi was struggling for oxygen... one file alone was marked ‘Most Urgent’... for the construction of a palace,’’ adding, ‘‘Not for

“When Delhi was struggling for oxygen... one file alone was marked ‘Most Urgent’... for the construction of a palace... not for ICU beds... only for a palace — Minister

oxygen, not for ICU beds... only for a palace.”

He claimed the cost rose from Rs 7 crore to Rs 58 crore and argued that the amount could have created over 2,300 ICU beds. Displaying a long expenditure list, he said, ‘‘This is not just a list. It is a record of misplaced priorities. The paper kept rolling, and so did the excess.’’ The list included luxury furniture, imported fit-

tings, chandeliers, gym equipment, multiple TVs, mini bars and barbecue units. He also alleged that 28 trees were cut without permission, structures were demolished, tenders were restricted, approvals were rushed, and an additional structure worth Rs 25 crore was being planned.

In another development, Cabinet Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa moved a condemnation motion regarding alleged atrocities under the AAP government in Punjab. Referring to the reported suicide of an official, he alleged undue pressure for tenders and said, ‘‘The Aam Aadmi Party’s pursuit of power... has reached such an extent that... lives are being lost.’’ He also cited cases involving alleged threats to officials, harassment and suicides in Punjab, stating that the situation reflects ‘‘fear and injustice.’’ The motion was unanimously passed. The proceedings were also marked by the absence

of Opposition MLAs. Speaker Vijender Gupta criticised the boycott, stating, ‘‘Do not use any pretext to stay away... By staying away, it creates an impression that the Opposition has nothing left to say.’’ He added, ‘‘In a democracy, both the Government and the Opposition carry equal weight... The public is watching,’’ and urged them to attend the House on March 27, recalling that even with just three MLAs earlier, his party never abandoned proceedings.

The Speaker also informed the House about repeated hoax bomb threats, saying, ‘‘The email claimed 16 RDX-IEDs had been planted... Despite these threats, the House proceedings continued consistently and without any interruption.’’ He said both emails had been handed over to police for investigation and directed a thorough probe.

Education Minister Ashish Sood defended the Budget 2026–27, calling it a ‘‘Budget that Redefines Good Governance.’’ He said, ‘‘This budget is not merely a financial document; rather, it serves as a clear roadmap for building a developed Delhi,’’ while criticising the Opposition for avoiding discussion. He highlighted record capital expenditure crossing Rs 32,000 crore, rising tax revenues, declining debt, and falling inflation to 1.13 per cent by December 2025. He also detailed education reforms including smart classrooms, AI labs, digital libraries, CM Shri schools, bicycles for 1.3 lakh girls, and expansion of technical education infrastructure.

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra highlighted increased allocations, noting tourism funding has risen to Rs 412 crore from Rs 121 crore, along with Rs 173 crore for art, culture and language.

LPG WAR: Govt denies crunch, AAP cries crisis

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A sharp political face-off erupted over LPG supply in the national capital on Wednesday, with the Delhi government asserting that there is no shortage, even as AAP MLAs staged protests outside the Assembly alleging a ‘‘deepening gas crisis.’’

Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa told the House that LPG supply remains stable and urged citizens not to believe rumours. ‘‘I would like to inform the citizens and the entire House that no rumours regarding LPG distribution in Delhi should be encouraged. The department is working with full vigilance to curb black marketing and ensure smooth supply,’’ he said.

Sirsa added that the situation has remained ‘‘completely normal’’ over the past 22–25 days, with no signs of overbooking or shortage. He said both domestic and commercial cylinders are being supplied on priority as per Central government policy, ensuring uninterrupted services, including to hospitals. ‘‘With the festive season approaching... not even for a single day or a single hour will there be any shortage any-



where,’’ he assured, adding that complaints would be addressed immediately. However, outside the Assembly, AAP MLAs led by Leader of Opposition Atishi held a protest, accusing the BJP-led government of failing to ensure gas supply. Raising slogans of ‘‘Narendra Modi Ne Kiya Surrender, Gayab Hua Gas Cylinder,’’ Atishi alleged, ‘‘Today, across the country, long queues are forming for a single gas cylinder... common people are suffering.’’

She further claimed, ‘‘BJP had promised free cylinders on Holi and Diwali... now cylinders are not available at all,’’ and accused the government of avoiding discussion in the House. ‘‘They are afraid that if Aam Aadmi Party legislators enter... their reality will be exposed,’’ she said. AAP leader Sanjeev Jha said, ‘‘People are standing in long queues... yet they are not getting gas.’’

City to get another windy drizzle

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In what experts are calling a rather unusual March, Delhi is set to experience another spell of strong winds, mild dust storms, and light rain on Thursday. The national capital recorded a maximum temperature of 33.5 degrees Celsius on Wednesday, two notches above normal.

The India Meteorological Department has forecast a thunderstorm with rain on Thursday, with the minimum temperature expected to settle

around 18 degrees Celsius and the maximum likely to reach 34 degrees Celsius.

‘‘Unusual rainfall activity has been observed this March. Typically, the month sees only isolated pre-monsoon showers, but this time there have been multiple spells of rain. This is due to a series of western disturbances, one of which has been active since March 15 and is approaching at a lower altitude than usual,’’ said Mahesh Palawat of Skymet.

He added that another western disturbance has

induced a cyclonic circulation over central Pakistan and adjoining parts of northwest Rajasthan and west Haryana.

‘‘As a result, parts of Delhi are likely to experience high wind speeds, light rain and mild dust storms tomorrow. While this system may not significantly impact temperatures immediately, a more pronounced effect is expected towards the end of the month,’’ he said. Explaining the outlook, Palawat said rainfall activity is likely towards the end of the month.

DJB plans to reorganise water distribution zones

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With the aim of strengthening its water distribution system and revenue collection, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) plans to conduct an area-specific study dividing the capital into six large zones, officials said on Wednesday. According to officials, one of the major aims of the study is to reduce non-revenue water (NRW) from the current 45 per cent to 15 per cent.

The DJB will be conducting the study in six water distribution zones — East, North East, South, North West, West and Southwest — keeping in mind the estimated population load till 2051.

‘‘DJB has launched a city-wide programme to reduce non-

revenue water and improve the efficiency, reliability, and financial sustainability of water service delivery. A study will be conducted for which a tender has been floated,’’ a senior official said.

As per the plan, individual studies will be conducted in each of the six zones — assessing specific area characteristics and existing infrastructure.

Based on the report, a water master plan will be prepared to divide the city and explore isolated ‘‘municipal water networks’’ for efficient functioning.

According to DJB, Delhi’s estimated water requirement is around 1,250 million gallons per day (MGD), based on a planning norm of 50 gallons per capita per day (GPCD).

Sri Lankan delegation visits NDMC for civic exchange

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A 19-member parliamentary delegation from Sri Lanka visited the New Delhi Municipal Council on Wednesday to exchange best practices in civic services and urban governance. The delegation was led by Asitha Niroshana Egoda Vithana.

During the interaction, NDMC Chairperson Keshav Chandra presented the Council’s integrated approach to sustainable urban development, highlighting initiatives that have contributed to making the NDMC area clean, green, and citizen-friendly. He also outlined the civic body’s revenue model, including taxes, user charges, and service-based income streams, while detailing

key sectors such as electricity, water supply, sewage management, roads, and green spaces.

A presentation by NDMC Secretary Rahul Singh showcased the transformation of the area under the Smart City Mission. Initiatives such as solar energy adoption, smart parking systems, intelligent transport solutions, and the NDMC 311 mobile application were highlighted as key enablers of efficient service delivery.

The delegation also reviewed sanitation and environmental measures, including mechanised cleaning, waste segregation, and the Reduce, Reuse, Recycle model. A visit to the Integrated Command and Control Centre demonstrated real-time governance and digital service integration.

— ‘THE CAPITAL WILL STAND ALONGSIDE MUMBAI, PUNE, AND GOA’ —

Lights, Camera, Delhi!: CM Rekha opens International Film Festival

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi marked a major cultural milestone on Wednesday with the grand inauguration of the International Film Festival Delhi (IFFD) 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, as Chief Minister Rekha Gupta reaffirmed the government’s vision of transforming the Capital into a global film hub.

The week-long festival, running from March 25 to 31, was inaugurated in the presence of ministers including Parvash Sahib Singh, Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Kapil Mishra, along with filmmakers, artists and dignitaries from India and abroad. The event featured a red carpet, cultural performances, gala premieres and concluded with the screening of the opening film ‘‘SIRAT.’’

Addressing the gathering, Gupta described the festival as a defining moment for Delhi’s cultural identity. ‘‘This is a historic initiative towards establishing Delhi as a global film and cultural centre,’’ she said, adding that the festival is ‘‘not



merely about films, but a celebration of dreams, emotions and stories that connect society.’’

Highlighting Delhi’s cultural legacy, she said the Capital is now ‘‘securing its place on the global film map’’ and will stand alongside major film hubs like Mumbai, Pune and Goa. She also underlined the government’s long-term vision to boost film tourism, create opportunities for youth and strengthen the creative economy. Initiatives such as CineXchange and

Her Lens aim to support emerging and women filmmakers, positioning Delhi as a ‘‘Creative Capital.’’ Tourism and Culture Minister Kapil Mishra called the festival a landmark moment, stating, ‘‘The International Film Festival Delhi... represents a historic milestone in positioning Delhi’s cultural identity on the global stage.’’

IFFD 2026 will showcase over 125 Indian and international films, along with masterclasses, panel discussions,

workshops and cultural performances. Prominent personalities including Manoj Bajpayee, Anupam Kher and Piyush Mishra are set to engage with audiences through interactive sessions. The festival schedule includes gala screenings, industry discussions on AI in filmmaking, cross-cultural cinema and independent films, along with sessions like ‘‘The Producer’s Chair’’ and ‘‘The Casting Eye.’’ A special highlight will be the screening of the restored classic Sholay, alongside international entries and regional cinema showcases.

Screenings will be held at Bharat Mandapam and multiple venues, including PVR cinemas across Delhi, with additional showcases at public spaces and special screening formats.

With a blend of cinematic heritage and modern innovation, IFFD 2026 positions Delhi as an emerging hub for global cinema, reinforcing the government’s push to integrate culture, creativity and economic growth through large-scale international events.

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‘SHAME ON YOU’

SC pulls up Hry Police, CWC; sets up SIT in minor rape case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Pulling up Haryana Police and Gurugram's Child Welfare Committee for "shameful", "reckless" and "insensitive" approach in the shocking case of rape of a three-year-old, the Supreme Court on Wednesday constituted a special team of women IPS officers to conduct a fair probe into the crime.

The top court also directed the Gurugram district and sessions judge to assign the horrific case to the special POC SO court presided over by a woman judicial officer.

Coming down hard on the investigation carried out so far and the gross mishandling of the case, the top court said, "Shame on you! Is this the way the state deals with crime? The child has undergone more horrifying repeated experiences than the crime itself."

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi said the present case reflects a "disturbing pattern" in which the police authorities have made concerted efforts to "shield the suspects"

HIGHLIGHTS

» The top court also directed the Gurugram district and sessions judge to assign the horrific case to the special POC SO court presided over by a woman judicial officer

» Coming down hard on the investigation carried out so far and the gross mishandling of the case, the top court said, 'Shame on you! Is this the

way the state deals with crime? The child has undergone more horrifying repeated experiences than the crime itself'



based on a report of a Child Welfare Committee (CWC) and instead of visiting the child, called her and parents to the police station and the CWC for recording of statements that too in front of the accused in a clear violation of norms. It said the manner in which the police authorities, ranging from the Commissioner of Police to the Sub-Inspector, have so far investigated the case discloses a "concerted and unwarranted attempt" to discredit the version of the minor victim and

to portray the concerns raised by her parents as exaggerated and unfounded.

The bench said in order to ensure a fair, dispassionate and independent investigation in the case it was constituting a Special Investigation Team (SIT) comprising ADGP Kala Ramachandran, SP Dr. Anshu Singla and DyCP Jasleen Kaur.

It said, "The matter came to light on February 2, 2026, whereupon the trauma, suffering, and distress endured by the child were

further aggravated by the insensitive, reckless and wholly irresponsible, investigative methods adopted by the Gurugram police in the course of investigation. The conduct and findings of the CWC, as reflected in its report dated February 5, 2026, have only served to compound such victimisation." The top court also frowned upon the proceedings before the judicial magistrate, before whom the minor victim was produced on February 6, and said he failed to ensure that the investigation proceeded on the correct legal premise that a prima facie offence under stringent section 6 of the the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act (POCSO Act) (aggravated penetrative sexual assault) was disclosed that entails punishment from 20 years imprisonment extendable to life term.

It said notwithstanding the gravity of the allegations and the material available on record, the police authorities have, for "wholly unjustified and extraneous reasons", sought to dilute the offence by erroneously classifying it under section 10 of the Act which entails punishment of five years extending up to seven years

rigorous imprisonment.

Justice Bagchi observed, "If this is the quality of understanding of sensitivity in case of a three-year-old child, what do you expect of the rule of law? You say it's not a case of rape but assault? We are indicating what's distressing. Highest police officials took that stance to bring down the offence to section 10 of the Act. It's for the courts to decide, not the CWC."

The bench further said as per the affidavit filed by the authorities the probe as on February 6, allegedly did not disclose the commission of any offence but in the very same affidavit, at a subsequent stage, it says that, pursuant to a representation made by the victim's father, the facts were re-verified on March 12. "This shifting and inconsistent stance raises serious concerns regarding the fairness and credibility of the investigation. In such circumstances, it is imperative that the incident be subjected to a thorough, impartial, and sensitive investigation, conducted with a humane approach that duly preserves the dignity of the minor victim and her parents," the bench said.

MEA: 4.26L return from WEST ASIA

NEW DELHI: Amid the West Asia conflict, a total of 1,043 Indian nationals, including 717 students, have crossed out of Iran with the assistance of the mission in Tehran, the Ministry of External Affairs said on Wednesday.

At an inter-ministerial briefing here on the West Asia situation, Aseem R Mahajan, Additional Secretary (Gulf), MEA, also said the overall flight situation continues to improve, and that around 4.26 lakh passengers have returned from the region to India since February 28.

"During this period, a total of 2,149 flights, including scheduled and non-scheduled flights of Indian as well as foreign carriers, have operated from the region to India," he said.

The MEA said it continues to closely monitor the evolving situation in the Gulf and the West Asia region.

"We are according the highest priority to ensure the safety, security, and well-being of the large Indian community in the region," Mahajan said.

The ministry's dedicated Control Room remains operational to address queries and support Indian nationals and their families.

"We continue to assist travel of Indian nationals in Iran

through Armenia and Azerbaijan, to India. A total of 1,043 Indian nationals, including 717 students and 326 other Indian citizens, have crossed out of Iran with our mission's assistance.

"We are also facilitating travel of Indian nationals from Israel via Jordan to India. In view of the flight restrictions from Kuwait, Bahrain and Iraq, we continue to facilitate travel of Indian nationals via Saudi Arabia," he added.

Mahajan said the mortal remains of an Indian national who had passed away on March 18 in an attack in Riyadh, have arrived in India earlier on Wednesday.

"We have been in regular touch with the family and express our deepest condolences to them at this difficult time," he said. The Indian missions in Oman, Iraq, and the UAE are in regular touch with the concerned authorities regarding a missing Indian national and for early repatriation of the mortal remains of the other deceased Indian national, the MEA official said.

On Tuesday evening, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met the Iranian envoy in India and talked about the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

AGENCIES

'Will he dictate to me?': CJI fumes over litigant's father calling his brother

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Wednesday took umbrage at the conduct of a litigant whose father made a phone call to the CJI's brother objecting to a judicial order regarding minority reservation for a medical post-graduate course.

The matter pertains to one Nikhil Kumar Punia, born into Haryana's Jaat Puniya community, seeking a minority reservation after converting to Buddhism in Uttar Pradesh's Subharti Medical College.

On January 28, the Supreme Court, while observing that the plea was a "new type of fraud", had directed an inquiry into the petitioner's minority certificates.

On Wednesday, the CJI was infuriated while referring to the "shocking" incident and said, "Nobody dares to do this. And you think I will transfer the case because of this? I have dealt with such elements for the last 23 years."

He went on and said, "Now you tell us why we should not initiate criminal contempt against the father of your client. What he (father) has done, should I disclose in open court?"

AGENCIES

From Page 1

Iran rejects US

diplomatic source added, calling the plan deceptive and misleading in its presentation.

The source explained that Iran has a clear understanding of what conditions it requires for a ceasefire and what it will reject.

The source also stated that there have been no direct Iran-United States talks since the war began – however, messages have been exchanged through a number of mediators.

The response from Iran came hours after sources confirmed to Al Jazeera that Pakistan had shared the US' ceasefire demands with Iran.

According to Al Jazeera's Osama Bin Javadi, Pakistan is in a unique position as a mediator because it has a Shia minority, and relatively good ties with Iran including cross-border trade.

It also has a defence agreement with Saudi Arabia, and a Sunni majority that is closely aligned with the Gulf states, he said. Pakistan's military leader also has a relationship with Trump, Javadi added.

Earlier, according to the AP, two officials from Pakistan described the 15-point US proposal broadly, saying it addressed sanctions relief, a rollback of Iran's nuclear program, limits on missiles and reopening the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's oil is shipped.

The 15-point plan now in Iranian hands is "a comprehensive deal" to reach a ceasefire, according to the Egyptian official.

Mediators are pushing for possible in-person talks between the Iranians and the Americans, perhaps as soon as Friday in Pakistan, the Egyptian and Pakistani officials said.

Trump has said the US is "in negotiations right now" and that the participants included special envoy Steve Witkoff, his son-in-law Jared Kushner, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Vice President JD Vance. He has not disclosed who from Iran they are in contact with, but said "the other side, I can tell you, they'd like to make a deal."

Press TV, like all of state TV channels controlled by hard-liners, offered its own five-point plan from the official who rejected the US proposal.

It included a halt to killings of its officials, means to make sure no other war is waged against it, reparations for the war, the end of hostilities and Iran's "exercise of sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz."

Those measures, particularly reparations and its continued chokehold over the Strait of Hormuz, likely will be unacceptable to the White House as energy supplies worldwide remain affected by the war.

Israeli officials, who have been advocating for Trump to continue the war against Iran, were surprised by the submission of a ceasefire plan, according

to a person who was briefed on the contours of the proposal and spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly.

An Egyptian official involved in the mediation efforts said the proposal also includes restrictions on Iran's support for armed groups. The officials spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss details not yet released.

Some of those points were nonstarters in negotiations before the war: Iran has insisted it won't discuss its ballistic missile program or its support of regional militias, which it views as key to its security. And its ability to control passage through the Strait of Hormuz represents one of its biggest strategic advantages.

Iran's attacks on regional energy infrastructure along with its restrictions on the strait have sent oil prices skyrocketing and sparked fears of a global energy crisis, in turn putting pressure on the US to find a way to end the chokehold and calm markets.

At least 1,000 troops from the 82nd Airborne Division will be sent to the Mideast in the coming days, three people with knowledge of the plans told The Associated Press.

The Pentagon is also in the process of sending about 5,000 more Marines, trained in amphibious assaults, and thousands of sailors to the region.

Any talks between the US and Iran would face monumental challenges. It's not clear who in Iran's government has the authority to negotiate — or would be willing to, as Israel has vowed to continue killing the country's leaders.

Iran remains highly suspicious of the United States, which twice under the Trump administration has attacked during high-level diplomatic talks, including with the Feb. 28 strikes that started the current war.

The Israeli military said it had completed several waves of airstrikes in Tehran. The army also said that as part of its strikes a day earlier it targeted an Iranian submarine development centre in Isfahan.

Drone and rocket fire from the Iran-back Hezbollah militant group continued unabated. Since entering the fighting, the group has fired rockets into northern Israel around the clock each day, disrupting the lives of hundreds of thousands of people.

Iran also kept up the pressure on its Gulf Arab neighbours. Saudi Arabia's defence ministry saying it had destroyed at least eight drones in the kingdom's oil-rich Eastern Province, and missile alert sirens sounding in Bahrain.

Kuwait said it shot down multiple drones but the General Civil Aviation Authority said one hit a fuel tank at Kuwait International Airport, sparking a fire that sent a huge plume of smoke into the sky.

Iran's death toll has passed 1,500, its Health Ministry has said. Israel says 20 people have died in the war, including two soldiers in Lebanon. At least 13 U.S. military members have been killed, along with more than a dozen civilians in the occupied West Bank and Gulf Arab states.

Authorities say more than 1,000 people have died in Lebanon, where Israel has targeted the Iran-linked Hezbollah militant group, which has also fired on Israel.

The news of potential negotiations drove down the price of oil. Brent crude oil, the international standard, has neared USD 120 a barrel during the conflict but was trading below USD 100 Wednesday. It is still up around 35 per cent from the start of the war.

PM told Trump

All Union ministers part of the high-level Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) -- Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah, External Affairs Minister Jaishankar and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman -- represented the government.

Union Health Minister JP Nadda and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju also attended. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri made a presentation before the gathering.

Tariq Anwar and Mukul Wasnik of the Congress, Dharmendra Yadav of the Samajwadi Party, Sasmit Patra of the Biju Janata Dal (BJD), Sanjay Jha of JD-U, Srikanth Shinde of Shiv Sena, Sanjay Singh of Aam Aadmi Party, John Brittas of CPI-M, Supriya Sule of NCP (SP), Arvind Sawant of Shiv Sena (UBT), Asaduddin Owaisi of AIMM were among the Opposition leaders who attended the meeting, which lasted for nearly two hours.

The sources said the government conveyed that there is no need for panic as India has enough stock with more crude oil and gas coming.

"We have already done advance order. Diversification of sources of oil and gas has been undertaken and now we are procuring from 41 countries," the government told the meeting.

It is a diplomatic success that four India-bound ships, carrying petroleum products, have already crossed the Strait of Hormuz while five more are expected to cross soon. There are 18 India-bound ships which are stranded around the Strait of Hormuz, the participants were told.

On the US attack and sinking of an Iranian ship, the government said that had it been in Indian waters it would have been saved but unfortunately the ship was near Sri Lankan waters.

"We are good friends with everyone - the US is our largest trading partner, Israel is our largest technological partner and we have good relations with Iran too," it said.

The opening remarks were made by Defence Minister Singh who chaired the meeting. Jaishankar and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri also spoke at the meeting.

During the Q and A session, it was mostly Jaishankar who replied to the opposition's queries and concerns. On a few occasions, Home Minister Shah also intervened.

Briefing reporters on the meeting, Rijiju said the meeting

was convened because PM Modi wanted it and information was shared about the crisis in West Asia.

On behalf of the government, comprehensive and detailed responses were provided, Rijiju said.

In the end, all opposition members stated that in this time of crisis, whatever decisions the government takes and whatever steps are required based on the situation, they will stand united and support them, he said.

Speaking with reporters, Anwar said an attempt was made to seek clarification from the government, but the meeting was "unsatisfactory".

Brittas said the government has been assuring the opposition that everything is safe. "The opposition parties expressed their disapproval of the government's silence. All the opposition leaders said that the government should have taken a position with regard to the unilateral attack against a sovereign independent country Iran by the United States. And there have been questions raised with regard to the visit of our Prime Minister to Tel Aviv, and also there were certain questions about the proactive role of Pakistan," Brittas said.

The all-party meeting came after PM Modi addressed Parliament on Monday and Tuesday, urging countrymen to "be prepared for every challenge". There is a strong possibility that the ill effects of this war will last for a long time, he said in his speeches.

Govt, oil firms

temporary spikes in sales and long queues at petrol pumps. Sharma clarified that there is no shortage at any retail outlet or oil terminal. "There are enough stocks of petrol and diesel and there is no shortage of any retail outlet. Oil terminals also have enough stocks," she said.

On LPG, officials said supplies remain affected due to disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz linked to the ongoing geopolitical situation. However, they maintained that there have been no instances of supply dry-outs and that cylinder deliveries are continuing. To manage demand, additional allocations have been made to states, while commercial LPG supply is being restored in phases and currently stands at about 50 per cent of normal levels, with priority for essential services such as restaurants, hotels and community kitchens.

To ease pressure on LPG, the government is pushing the transition to piped natural gas. Priority allocation has ensured full supply to domestic PNG users and CNG transport, while industrial and commercial consumers are receiving around 80 per cent of their usual supply. City gas distribution companies have been directed to expand PNG connections, with states asked to speed up approvals and simplify permissions.

In the last 25 days, 2.5 lakh new PNG connections have been issued and 2.20 lakh LPG users have shifted to PNG, according

to official data. Additional measures include increasing domestic LPG production, allocating an extra 48,000 kilolitres of kerosene to states, and promoting alternative fuels such as electricity, PNG and coal.

Enforcement agencies have also acted against hoarding and black marketing. More than 2,700 raids have been conducted so far, leading to the seizure of around 2,000 cylinders, registration of over 650 FIRs and 155 arrests.

Oil marketing companies echoed the government's stance, stressing that supply chains remain intact. Indian Oil Corporation said its outlets are well-stocked and fully operational. Its chairman, A S Sahney, said there is no shortage of petrol or diesel and cautioned that unverified rumours can create unnecessary concern and disrupt normal supply patterns.

Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd termed reports of shortages in some areas as completely unfounded, noting that India is a net exporter of petrol and diesel and has adequate stocks of crude oil, petrol, diesel and aviation turbine fuel. The company said its operations are running smoothly and it remains committed to uninterrupted supply.

Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd also said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel or LPG, advising consumers to continue normal consumption and not be misled by rumours.

The reassurances come as the conflict in West Asia has disrupted supplies of crude oil, liquefied natural gas and LPG. India has mitigated the impact by sourcing crude from regions such as West Africa, Latin America and the United States.

LNG supplies have been affected after facilities in Qatar, a major supplier, were hit, leading to prioritisation of gas for domestic households and CNG transport, with reduced allocation for some industrial users, including fertiliser plants.

LPG remains the most affected fuel, as India depends on imports for about 60 per cent of its requirement, much of it sourced from Gulf countries. With supplies constrained, the government has prioritised household consumption and reduced allocations to commercial establishments by at least half.

Reiterating its advisory, the government said it is taking all necessary steps to ensure uninterrupted availability of fuels and urged citizens to avoid panic buying, conserve energy and rely on verified information.

Congress faces

"The party is exploring legal options and may approach the court for relief," a source said.

While there has been no official response from the Congress, MP Karti Chidambaram said any rules governing such properties should be applied uniformly and not selectively.

The Akbar Road property is closely tied to the party's mod-

ern political history. After the Congress split following its 1977 electoral defeat, Indira Gandhi's faction began functioning from the bungalow, which was offered by loyalist G Venkatswamy. The premises later became the centre of the party's organisational revival and remained its headquarters through the tenures of Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi, P V Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh.

Before its association with the Congress, the bungalow had a varied past. It once housed Sir Reginald Maxwell of the Viceroy's Executive Council during British rule. In the early 1960s, it served as the residence of Myanmar's ambassador Daw Khin Kyi, where her daughter Aung San Suu Kyi spent several formative years.

Party veterans have often spoken of their emotional connection to the Akbar Road office, even after the shift to a new address.

Four IITs, JNU

and Management Studies and Marketing. The Marketing ranking marks a first for India, which had not featured in the subject's global rankings earlier.

Institutions such as IIT Bombay, IIT Kharagpur and IIT Madras are among those placed in the top 50, alongside JNU and BITS Pilani.

QS CEO Jessica Turner said the country's progress reflects more than expansion. "India's rise this year is not just about scale, it is about momentum in quality and global competitiveness," she said, noting improvements across engineering, technology and business disciplines.

IIT Delhi emerged as the most comprehensive performer among Indian institutions, with six top-50 rankings. It leads nationally in four subjects, including Chemical Engineering at 48th, its first appearance in the top bracket, and Electrical and Electronic Engineering at 36th. It also ranked 44th in Mechanical, Aeronautical and Manufacturing Engineering and 36th in the Engineering and Technology category, while placing second in Computer Science at 45th.

Agniveers

wardens, Special Police Officers and positions in the State Disaster Response Force.

Haryana has already rolled out a 20 per cent quota for Agniveers in uniformed services and certain Group C posts. Uttarakhand has also announced similar reservations in police and other uniformed services, aligning with the Centre's rehabilitation plan.

LPG supply

The policy comes at a time when India is dealing with supply constraints in LPG due to disruptions linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. Damage to liquefaction facilities in the Gulf

and the continued blockage of the Strait of Hormuz have affected supplies from key sources, prompting the government to push for alternative arrangements. Officials said the move is intended to reduce dependence on a single fuel and ensure better allocation of LPG to regions without pipeline access.

Piped natural gas, which is supplied directly to kitchens through pipelines, removes the need for cylinder refills and is sourced through a mix of domestic production and diversified imports. The government sees it as a more reliable option during global supply disruptions.

Speaking at a media briefing, Joint Secretary Sujata Sharma said authorised entities operating in designated geographical areas will notify LPG users about the availability of PNG connections. "Such users are expected to switch within three months, failing which LPG supplies will be stopped," she said.

The directive forms part of the Natural Gas and Petroleum Products Distribution Order, 2026, which seeks to accelerate the expansion of pipeline infrastructure and streamline approval processes. Officials described it as a "time bound framework" aimed at improving last mile connectivity and facilitating a transition to cleaner fuels.

Oil Secretary Neeraj Mittal, in a post on X, said the reforms reflect how "a crisis has been turned into an opportunity" through measures that ease doing business and support infrastructure growth.

The order also introduces provisions to speed up permissions for laying pipelines. Public authorities are required to grant right of way approvals within fixed timelines, failing which permissions will be deemed granted. They are also barred from imposing charges beyond those specified under the new rules.

In residential complexes, entities controlling access must grant permission within three working days, and PNG connections are to be provided within 48 hours. Applications for such connections cannot be rejected. If access is denied, designated officers with powers similar to a civil court can intervene to resolve disputes and grant necessary approvals.

Companies authorised to supply PNG must begin pipeline work within four months of receiving approval or risk penalties, including loss of exclusivity in the area.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board has been designated as the nodal agency to oversee implementation, including monitoring approvals, compliance and any rejections.

The order further clarifies that if housing authorities fail to grant permission for pipeline access, a notice will be issued, and LPG supplies may still be discontinued three months later. However, households will retain LPG access if a no-object certificate is issued on technical grounds, with authorised entities required to document such cases and review them once connectivity becomes feasible.



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REGULATING RECRUITMENT, DEPUTATION, PROMOTION

Govt introduces in RS ‘umbrella law’ for CAPFs to regulate service rules

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: An “umbrella law” introduced by the Union government on Wednesday for Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) will regulate recruitment, deputation, promotion, and other conditions of service for their officers.

All CAPFs – CRPF, CISF, BSF, ITBP and SSB - are governed by their respective Acts.

The rules under these Acts govern the recruitment and conditions of service for Group A General Duty Officers and other officers and members in the CAPFs. Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai on Wednesday introduced the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill, 2026, in the Rajya Sabha.

The Bill provides that to appoint officers from the Indian Police Service in CAPFs, 50 per cent of the posts will be filled by deputation in the rank of inspector general and a minimum of 67 per cent of the posts by deputation in the rank of additional director general.

Posts in the ranks of special



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

director general and director general shall be filled by deputation only, it says.

The proposed legislation comes after the Supreme Court, in October last year, dismissed the Centre’s plea seeking a review of its 2025 verdict that directed that IPS officers’ deputation in the CAPFs up to the level of Senior Administrative Grade (SAG) should be “progressively reduced” and asked for a cadre review to be carried out in six months. “... the number of posts earmarked for deputation in the cadres of

the CAPFs up to the level of Senior Administrative Grade (SAG) should be progressively reduced over a period of time, say within an outer limit of two years,” the apex court had said.

According to the Bill’s statement of objects and reasons, the expanding functional and operational requirements have led to the distinct organisational structure of these forces.

“In recent years, due to the absence of an umbrella law, regulatory provisions have evolved in a fragmented manner, resulting in several litigation on ser-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » All CAPFs – CRPF, CISF, BSF, ITBP and SSB - are governed by their respective Acts
- » The rules under these Acts govern the recruitment and conditions of service for Group A General Duty Officers and other officers and members in the CAPFs
- » The Bill was introduced by MoS for Home Nityanand Rai on Wednesday

cations not only for institutional morale but also for the operational effectiveness of forces responsible for protecting India’s internal stability and border security,” the group had said. The bill states that under Article 312 of the Constitution, the IPS is an All-India Service and its officers are posted in the Union and the States.

“Historically, Indian Police Service officers are an integral and important part of the Central Armed Police Forces, who have been serving on deputation along with officers and members of these Forces,” the objectives of the bill state.

The CAPFs perform functions relating to national security and anti-insurgency in close coordination with the state authorities, it said.

“Therefore, in the interest of maintaining Centre-State relations by ensuring close coordination between the Union and the States for effective operational functioning, it is essential to maintain the existing system of deputation of the Indian Police Service Officers in the CAPFs,” the Bill said.

Govt strengthens support for Kashmiri migrants

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Centre has outlined a range of welfare measures being extended to Kashmiri migrant families, focusing on financial assistance, food security, housing, and employment opportunities. The initiatives are being implemented under the Security-Related Expenditure (SRE) framework and the Prime Minister’s Development Package (PMDP), aimed at improving living conditions and ensuring long-term support for displaced families.

At present, registered migrant families receive monthly cash assistance of Rs 3,250 per person, capped at Rs 13,000 per family. In addition,

INSIGHT

- » The initiatives aimed at improving living conditions and ensuring long-term support for displaced families
- » At present, registered migrant families receive monthly cash assistance of Rs 3,250 per person, capped at Rs 13,000 per family

free ration is being provided, with Kashmiri migrants receiving rice, atta, and sugar under a fixed monthly scale. Separate ration provisions are in place for migrants settled in Jammu.

This information was shared by the government in a written reply to a question in the Rajya Sabha.

Meanwhile, the government is also maintaining residential camps and flats that house migrant families in Jammu, ensuring basic facilities and upkeep. Alongside relief measures, employment has been a key focus. Out of 6,000 posts earmarked for Kashmiri migrant youth, appointment orders have already been issued to 5,896 candidates—covering over 98 per cent of the targeted positions. Efforts have also been made to simplify access to services. Online facilities for registration and issuance of key documents such as domicile, income, EWS, and

migrant certificates are now available. Aadhaar-based DBT has been introduced to ensure timely and transparent delivery of financial assistance directly into beneficiaries’ accounts.

To stay connected with migrant communities, the government has been conducting outreach programmes and grievance redressal camps across the country. Cultural and social initiatives, including events promoting language, health, and sports, are also being organised to preserve community identity and well-being. The government has also approved the construction of 6,000 transit accommodation units for migrant employees working in various departments.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Name of work : Schedule Maintenance and repair contract of RMPUs of EOG LHB RMPU AC coaches including their sick line attention for heavy repairs work and On-board electrical escorting duties on AC coaches in Primary based Trains of electrical coaching ACC/Delhi & Elect/Chg./Delhi Sarai Rohilla Depot over Delhi Division for three years.

Tender No. : 30-Elect-7TR-Chg-2025-26

Approx. Cost of the work in (Rs.): Rs. 10,50,96,881.39/-

Cost of tender form : Rs. 0.00

Address of the Office : Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/Chg/Northern Railway, New Delhi.

Earnest Money : Rs. 21,01,900/-

Period of completion of work : 36 Months

Last date & time of submission of tender : 16.04.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.

And opening of tender : 16.04.2026 at 15.01 hrs.

Website & notice board : www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. DEE/Chg/DLI

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1028/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
INVITATION OF TENDERS
THROUGH E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM

Tender Notice No. 96 /2025-2026 **Date : 25.03.2026**

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. Tender N. No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01 19260759	BATTERY BOX ASSEMBLY	81 NOS	16.04.26
02 08255249	POWER CABLE, SIZE 2 CORE X 25 Sq. mm	305.5 KM	21.04.26
03 08265168	SUPPLY OF MSDAC 05 DP SYSTEM	117 SET	28.04.26

NOTE -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

1009/29

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय
पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर
लापता: आवश्यक सूचना

गुमशुदा प्रियंका मुंडा उम्र-16 वर्ष।

उपरोक्त प्रसंग एवं विषय के संबंध में सूचित करना है कि आवेदक सह पिता श्यामपद मुंडा के द्वारा अपनी बेटी प्रियंका मुंडा उम्र-16 वर्ष की गुमशुदगी के संबंध में संबंधित थाना बहरागोड़ा को लिखित में आवेदन दिये हैं। आवेदन में इनके द्वारा बताया गया कि गुमशुदा प्रियंका मुंडा उम्र-16 वर्ष, पिता-श्यामपद मुंडा, साठ-झरिया, पो-गुहीयापाल, थाना-बहरागोड़ा, जिला-पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर जो दिनांक-09.03.26 की सुबह करीब 09-10 बजे बकरी चराने के लिए गांव के खेत की ओर गई हुई थी, करीब दो (02) घंटे बिना जाने के बाद भी उसके घर वापस नहीं लौटने के कारण परिवारवालों ने अपने स्तर से काफी खोजबीन किया परन्तु कुछ पता नहीं चल सका।

गुमशुदा का इलाज निम्न प्रकार है :-कद-05 फीट 02 इंच, रंग-गोरा, पहचान चिह्न-गले में लाल धागा में लोकेट पहने हुए, पहनावा-सलवार सूट।

अतः आप सभी जन साधारण से अनुरोध है कि उपरोक्त गुमशुदा के संबंध में किसी प्रकार की जानकारी प्राप्त होती है तो इसकी सूचना वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक, पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर के कार्यालय में निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर सूचित करें।

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक, पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर: 0657-2431006
पुलिस अधीक्षक ग्रामीण, पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर: 9470199228
एस&डीओपीओ, घाटशिला : 9431706485
: 9431706526

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक, पूर्वी सिंहभूम, जमशेदपुर

PR 376011 (Police)25-26"D

POLICE HELPLINE (EMERGENCY DIAL)-112 CHILD HELPLINE-1098
WOMEN HELPLINE-1091 DOMESTIC ABUSE HELPLINE-181
CYBER CRIME HELPLINE-1930 AMBULANCE SERVICE-108

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

Name of work with location, Cost of work and Earnest money

1. Total 16 Nos. provision of cover shed in LHS on LC-5, 6, 8, 11, 21, 27, 27A, 28, 46 in NK section & LC Nos. 91, 65, 66, 77, 82, 81, 101 in the DUK section under ADEN/KUN.

2. Drainage improvement works like provision of sump well, approach hum, sealing of construction joints for water proofing of RUBS and to avoid water logging of RUBS in the section of SSE/WISNP under ADEN/PNP.

3. Raising and extension of platform No. 1 & 2 from Rail Level to High Level at AMIN in the section of SSE(W)KUM under ADEN/KUN.

Approx. Cost of work: 1. ₹13,77,29,209.07 2. ₹2,32,50,329.99
3. ₹2,75,49,331.28

Earnest Money

Earnest Money should be in the form of net banking or payment gateway only. **Note:** FDR or Demand Draft will not be accepted as EMD for tender invited under IREPS as per Railway Boards letter No. 2015/CE-I/CT/5/1 dated 31.08.2016

1. ₹27,54,600/- 2. ₹4,65,100/- 3. ₹5,51,000/-

Completion period 1. 12 Months 2. 06 Months 3. 12 Months

Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender Upto 15.00 hrs. on 17.04.2026 Opening of e-tender at 15.00 hrs. on 17.04.2026

Website particulars, published-tender, notice location etc., complete details of tender can be seen and Website where the tender form can be downloaded

Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

Similar Nature of Work: Any Civil work other than Track work

Note: All attachments must be self attested by the tenderers and the affidavit it should be submitted in the new form attached with tender conditions as per Annexure XXIV is compulsory.

No.: 128-W/280/Tender Notice/25-26/W4 (NIT-52-54)
Dated: 25.03.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1012/2026

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
IN THE COURT OF
Dr. Renu Solkhie
Additional Civil Judge
(Senior Division), Rewari
SATYPAL
Vs.
VIKRAM
CNR No. HRRRE02-000474-2023
Next Date 29-04-2026
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
21. MAYA D/O RATI RAM S/o NAND LAL
22. SHANTI D/O RATI RAMS/O NAND LAL
VILLAGE LISAN DISTT. REWARI
In above titled case, the defendant(s)/respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **29-04-2026 at 10:00 a.m.** For details logon to <https://highcourthd.gov.in/hrs> = **district Notice&district=Rewari**
Sd/- **Dr. Renu Solkhie**
Additional Civil Judge
(Senior Division),
Rewari
Date 25.03.2026

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Veteran Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, who is admitted at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital here, is stable and under close medical supervision, doctors said on Wednesday.

According to hospital authorities, she was admitted at around 10.22 pm on Tuesday. Chairman Dr Ajay Swaroop said that her condition remains stable and a team of doctors is closely monitoring her health.

Doctors are conducting further examinations to check for a possible infection in the stomach and urinary tract, and antibiotics have been administered as part of the treatment, the hospital said.

Sources had earlier said that Gandhi was unwell, possibly due to the weather change, and was admitted for observation.

They said there is no cause for concern and her condition is not serious.

FCRA amendment: Govt vows action on ‘forced’ conversions

Centre introduces FCRA Amendment Bill in Lok Sabha

MPOST BUREAU

The Bill proposes the creation of an Authority to seize and manage assets of NGOs that lose licence

said that the Bill would give sweeping power to the executive without any constitutional safeguards.

Trinamool Congress member Pratima Mondal, while expressing objection to the bill, said it is “dangerous” and “draconian” as all power is going to be vested with the central government.

“The central government will have absolute power without any constitutional safeguard,” she said, adding that the legislation will ensure centralisation of authority.

After a brief debate, Krishna Prasad Tenneti, who was in the chair, called for a vote on the motion, which was accepted by voice vote.

The legislation will significantly tighten its oversight of foreign-funded organisations,

proposing the creation of a powerful new authority to seize and manage the assets of non-profits that lose their licence.

It entails a comprehensive statutory framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets through a ‘designated authority’. At present, approximately 16,000 associations are registered under the FCRA and receive around Rs 22,000 crore annually.

The Bill provides for timelines for receipt and utilisation under prior permission; regulates dealing with assets during suspension of registration; provides for cessation of certificate upon expiry, non-renewal or refusal of renewal; rationalises penalties and introduces prior approval of the central government for initiation of investigation.

It also seeks to reduce punishment from five years imprisonment to one year for whoever accepts, or assists any person, political party or organisation in accepting any foreign contribution or any currency or security from a foreign source in contravention of any provision of FCRA.

‘Nearly 70K cases of govt employees pending adjudication’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Nearly 70,000 cases of government employees are pending adjudication in the Central Administrative Tribunal, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

The Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) is the competent authority that adjudicates grievances and disputes arising out of the conditions of service of Central and state government employees.

These pending grievances include cases related to pay, promotion, career progression, pension and similar matters, Union Minister of State for Personnel Jitendra Singh said in a written reply.

“Since its inception in the year 1985, the CAT has received 9,88,738 cases for adjudication, out of which 9,19,157 cases have been disposed till 31.01.2026, leaving 69,581 cases under adjudication presently,” Singh said.

The number of cases instituted, disposed and pending year-wise since the inception of the tribunal are available in the annual report of Department of Personnel and Training, which can be accessed through the link <https://dopt.gov.in/sites/default/files/AR2024-25Eng-lish.pdf>, Singh said.

Rlys expands services, adds coaches as passenger demand surges: Govt in LS

‘Passenger traffic in unreserved coaches risen steadily after pandemic years’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government told the Parliament on Wednesday that Railways has added 1,024 new trains, extended 907 services, and increased the frequency of 168 trains over the past five years in an attempt to meet the nation’s rising passenger demand, continuing the effort to make travel and lodging easier for passengers. In order to increase lodging capacity, railways also added 4,651 carriages during that time.

Railways Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw stated in a written response to the Lok Sabha that the occupancy pattern on trains fluctuates between peak and lean seasons, with some lines seeing reduced use at other times and popular routes frequently operating at full capacity during rush hours.

According to the ministry data, between 2021-22 and February 2026, the Railways introduced 444 train services originating or terminating in the eastern and north-eastern

KEY POINTS

- » The occupancy pattern on trains fluctuates between peak and lean seasons, with some lines seeing reduced use at other times and popular routes frequently operating at full capacity during rush hours
- » Between 2021-22 and February 2026, the



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Railways introduced 444 train services originating or terminating in the eastern and north-eastern region, including 75 pairs of trains serving stations in Bihar

region, including 75 pairs of trains serving stations in Bihar. Railways have also stepped up the availability of non-AC travel to cater to low- and middle-income passengers. Around 1,250 general coaches were used in long-distance trains in 2024-25, while 860 coaches have been added permanently in the current financial year up to February 2026.

At present, nearly 70 per cent of the total coach stock on the rail network consists of non-AC coaches, with about

62,000 non-AC coaches compared to roughly 27,000 AC coaches, the Rail minister mentioned in his reply. Adding, the number of seats available for non-AC passengers stands at about 54 lakh, accounting for nearly 78 per cent of the total seating capacity.

Recently, reports emerged that Indian Railways has increased the proportion of AC coaches to improve profitability, however, the minister emphasised that production of 17,000 non-AC coaches,

including general and sleeper class, is underway to increase affordable travel options.

According to him, waiting list trends are also routinely observed, new services are added, or current trains are extended, run more frequently, or given additional coaches as needed. The minister said rationalisation of waiting list limits has also been carried out in line with the number of available berths in different classes.

Passenger traffic in general and unreserved coaches has also risen steadily after the pandemic years. The number of such passengers increased from 553 crore in 2022-23 to 609 crore in 2023-24 and further to 651 crore in 2024-25, reflecting growing reliance on affordable rail travel.

To handle the seasonal rush, railways have been operating a large number of special trains during festivals, holidays and vacation periods. Around 40,500 special train trips were run in 2023-24, which increased to about 85,400 in 2024-25.

mp
EDITORIAL
DOUBLE
STANDARDS?

Israel's stated objective in the ongoing Middle East conflict—to prevent Iran from acquiring nuclear weapons—may appear, at first glance, as a defensible security doctrine. But it rests on a contradiction so stark that it risks collapsing under its own weight. The reality is this: Israel is widely believed to possess a substantial nuclear arsenal, developed outside global oversight and sustained through deliberate ambiguity. Yet it claims the right to unilaterally enforce a nuclear red line against Iran. This is not merely strategic inconsistency; it is the institutionalisation of a global double standard. In a region already defined by distrust and volatility, such asymmetry does not deter escalation—it invites it.

For decades, Israel has operated within a carefully maintained grey zone—neither confirming nor denying its nuclear status, while ensuring that the world understands its capabilities. The Dimona facility has long been at the centre of this shadow architecture, with intelligence assessments and whistleblower accounts consistently pointing to a mature weapons programme dating back to the late 1960s. Crucially, Israel has remained outside the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty and has never subjected its facilities to international inspections. This is not accidental; it is strategic design. Nuclear opacity has allowed Israel to enjoy the benefits of deterrence without the obligations of accountability. And it has done so with tacit acceptance from Western powers, which have effectively normalised an exception that they would deny to others.

Iran, in contrast, is treated not as a nuclear power but as a perpetual suspect. Its programme has been scrutinised, sanctioned, negotiated, and dismantled in cycles that reflect geopolitics as much as non-proliferation concerns. The 2015 nuclear deal was a rare moment of structured restraint, placing verifiable limits on Iran's enrichment activities. Its collapse in 2018 did not just free Iran from those constraints; it also signalled that compliance offers no guarantee of long-term stability. Since then, Iran has expanded its enrichment capacity, but the leap from enrichment to weaponisation remains significant—and, by most credible assessments, incomplete. The oft-repeated claim that Iran is "weeks away" from a bomb has persisted for decades, less as an intelligence conclusion and more as a political narrative. In reality, Iran appears to be positioning itself at the nuclear threshold—close enough to matter, but not crossing the line.

The larger danger lies not in Iran's ambitions alone, but in the precedent being reinforced. When the global order signals that nuclear weapons are acceptable for some and unacceptable for others, it does not prevent proliferation—it legitimises it. The logic of deterrence is inherently contagious. If nuclear capability guarantees security for one state, it becomes a rational pursuit for others. This is not theoretical. Countries with advanced technological capacity—South Korea, Japan, even Saudi Arabia—have, at various points, flirted with the idea of developing nuclear options in response to regional threats. The Canberra Commission warned nearly three decades ago that the existence of nuclear weapons in any state would drive their spread. That warning now appears less like caution and more like prophecy. A rules-based order that applies rules selectively is not an order—it is a hierarchy.

What makes the current moment particularly precarious is that the façade of control is beginning to crack. The UN Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons reflects a growing frustration among non-nuclear states with the entrenched inequities of the system. Yet the treaty remains largely symbolic so long as nuclear-armed states refuse to engage with it. Meanwhile, flashpoints like the targeting of Dimona underscore how quickly nuclear ambiguity can turn into nuclear risk. A single miscalculation—whether through escalation, misinterpretation, or technological failure—could transform a regional conflict into a catastrophe with global consequences. If the objective is truly to prevent nuclear proliferation, then the starting point cannot be selective enforcement. It must be universal accountability. Until nuclear powers, declared or undeclared, are willing to subject themselves to the same standards they demand of others, the world will remain locked in a dangerous illusion: that nuclear stability can be preserved through unequal restraint. History suggests otherwise.

NEXUS
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS
AN AUTHOR AND
A FORMER
CIVIL SERVANT

The success of
VIEWS lies not
in scale alone,
but in its method.
It rejects top-
down delivery
models in favour
of community
ownership, where
farmers are not
beneficiaries but
decision-makers

PLURAL
ETHOS



AMITABHA CHANDA

THE WRITER IS
A BRAIN AND
SPINE SURGEON,
CURRENTLY THE
DIRECTOR OF
NEUROSURGERY
AT C. K. BIRLA
HOSPITALS | CMRI,
KOLKATA

In India, the
concept carries
a meaning far
removed from its
Western origins,
rooted instead
in a civilizational
ethos that
accommodates
diversity without
erasing faith
from public life

Rewriting Rural Economies

VIEWS is reshaping agriculture through women-led, climate-resilient practices—proving sustainable livelihoods can emerge from local knowledge, collective action and institutional support

VIEWS (Voluntary Integration for Education and Welfare of Society) began as an organic farming movement in Odisha and has evolved into a leading organisation promoting climate-resilient and nutrition-secure livelihoods in Ganjam, Gajapati, and the tribal pockets of Mayurbhanj. It was the proud recipient of the Nexus of Good Annual Award, 2025.

The initiative empowers tribal and Dalit women farmers to adopt sustainable practices such as the System of Rice Intensification (SRI), organic composting, and millet-based farming systems, increasing paddy productivity and reviving millets as climate-resilient crops. To ensure fresh and nutritious food in every household, VIEWS promotes nutrition gardens in homes and schools, providing vegetables and greens year-round.

Knowledge sharing is central to the movement. Through Farmer Field Schools and Bio-Resource Centres, farmers learn organic input preparation, natural pest control, and sustainable farming techniques. A network of Community Resource Persons supports women's collectives in planning, record-keeping, and climate adaptation at the village level.

By combining traditional knowledge with modern innovation, VIEWS empowers women farmers to lead their communities toward food security, climate resilience, and self-reliance across rural and tribal Odisha.

Impact on Odisha's Farming Communities
Across the hills of Gajapati, the fertile plains of Ganjam, and the tribal belts of Mayurbhanj, a quiet but powerful revolution is unfolding. Farmers—especially women from marginalised and tribal communities—are taking charge of their land, reviving traditional crops, and building climate-resilient livelihoods.

At the heart of this transformation is VIEWS (Voluntary Integration for Education and Welfare of Society), a grassroots NGO founded in 2002 with a mission to empower the most vulnerable communities of Odisha through education, livelihoods, and climate action. Over the past two decades, VIEWS has evolved into one of the leading organisations in sustainable agriculture and women-led livelihood promotion in eastern India.

Building Climate-Resilient Agriculture
In the face of erratic rainfall, rising temperatures, and shrinking resources, VIEWS has worked to build an ecosystem of climate-resilient agriculture rooted in local wisdom and agroecological principles.

Through Farmer Field Schools (FFS) and Bio-Resource Centres (BRCs), VIEWS has reached thousands of small and marginal farmers with training on the System of Rice Intensification (SRI), organic composting, vermiculture, and natural pest management. These practices have reduced input costs, improved soil fertility, and increased yields, allowing poor farmers to move from subsistence to sustainable surplus.



VIEWS operates through an integrated approach that combines agriculture, livelihoods and governance

Promoting Millets and Local Food Security

In the drought-prone villages of Ganjam and the tribal hills of Mayurbhanj, VIEWS has spearheaded a revival of traditional millet-based farming systems. Once seen as "poor man's food," millets like ragi, kodo, and foxtail are now recognised as "smart foods" for their resilience and nutritional value.

VIEWS supports women's collectives to cultivate millets organically and process them through community-based millet processing units. These small-scale enterprises, managed by Self-Help Groups (SHGs), not only generate local income but also ensure that nutritious grains remain accessible to village families.

Alongside millets, VIEWS promotes nutrition gardens in households and schools to address malnutrition. More than 1,000 families have established small backyard gardens producing vegetables and greens year-round, improving dietary diversity for children and women.

Bio-Resource Centres and Farmer Field Schools

The Bio-Resource Centres (BRCs) established by VIEWS in Ganjam and Gajapati serve as demonstration hubs for eco-friendly agriculture. Farmers learn to produce organic inputs—biofertilizers, compost, and pest repellents—from locally available materials. The BRCs also host community meetings, seed exchanges, and workshops on soil testing, water management, and crop rotation.

Farmer Field Schools further strengthen farmer-to-farmer learning. These platforms bring together local farmers to test new techniques in their fields, compare results, and make collective decisions. The participatory approach not only improves adoption rates but also builds farmers' confidence as innovators rather than mere beneficiaries.

Empowering Community Resource Persons in Agriculture

One of the most successful innovations of VIEWS has been the creation of Community Resource Persons (CRPs)—trained local farm-

ers, mostly women, who act as village-level facilitators and peer educators.

CRPs conduct demonstrations, offer on-site advisory support, and help women's groups in record-keeping and planning. They bridge the gap between scientific knowledge and local practice, ensuring sustainability beyond project cycles. Their leadership has become instrumental in mobilising communities for climate adaptation and local governance.

Strengthening Gram Panchayat-Level Institutions through Amo Goan-Amo Yogna

Recognising that true sustainability requires collective ownership, VIEWS has strengthened community-based organisations (CBOs) at the Gram Panchayat (GP) level. These include SHG federations, farmer producer groups, and local development committees that prepare Village Development Plans (VDPs) focusing on agriculture, water management, and climate change adaptation.

The plans are linked with MGNREGS and other government schemes to leverage public resources for soil and water conservation, farm ponds, plantation drives, and other climate-resilient measures.

By aligning grassroots efforts with local governance, VIEWS ensures that small farmers—especially women and tribal groups—have a voice in decision-making processes that shape their livelihoods.

Diversifying Livelihoods Beyond Farming

To reduce dependence on mono-cropping and unstable agricultural income, VIEWS promotes diversified livelihood opportunities.

In the coastal villages of Ganjam, where many families depend on fishing, VIEWS supports sustainable fisheries and fish-based micro-enterprises. More than 300 households now earn a steady income through fish processing, drying, and packaging, while adopting environmentally responsible practices to protect marine ecosystems.

In inland villages, livestock and poultry units provide supplementary income for landless and

single women. Over 850 families have received support in goatery and backyard poultry, coupled with veterinary linkages and training.

Women's groups are also engaged in mushroom cultivation, vegetable farming, and value-added food processing, turning agriculture into a year-round source of income.

Women-Led Enterprises and Farmer-Producer Company

VIEWS has long recognised women as the backbone of rural agriculture. Through 600 Self-Help Groups (SHGs), women have built collective savings, gained financial literacy, and ventured into small enterprises.

A milestone achievement is the establishment of a women-led Farmer Producer Company (FPO) in Ganjam, enabling small producers to access better markets, bulk inputs, and financial services. The FPO promotes aggregation, branding, and collective marketing of organic produce, ensuring fair prices and reducing exploitation by middlemen.

This institutional approach transforms women farmers from wage earners to entrepreneurs—empowering them to lead local economic development.

Skill Development and Youth Engagement

Rural youth are vital to sustaining agricultural innovation. VIEWS has trained 1,650 youth in market-driven skills such as agri-entrepreneurship, food processing, digital marketing, and repair of agri-machinery. Many have established microenterprises or found employment locally, reducing migration and creating role models for others.

Impact and Key Achievements

Over the years, VIEWS integrated livelihood programmes have yielded measurable and lasting impacts across southern and tribal Odisha:

- ▶ 600 SHGs promoted across villages;
- ▶ 18,300 farmers practising organic farming;
- ▶ 15,100 farmers adopting the System of Rice Intensification (SRI);
- ▶ 8,500 farmers adopting climate-resilient practices;
- ▶ 2,200 farmers introduced to pulse cultivation;
- ▶ 1,650 youth trained in market-driven skills;
- ▶ 160 ultra-poor women supported in enterprise creation;
- ▶ 850 families supported in livestock-based livelihoods;
- ▶ 300 households supported in fishery-based ventures;
- ▶ 330 women trained in mushroom cultivation;
- ▶ 6,500 households engaged in commercial vegetable farming;
- ▶ 1 women-led Farmer Producer Company established in Ganjam.

These numbers reflect not only the scale of outreach but also the depth of transformation—where local communities have transitioned from vulnerability to self-reliance, guided by the principles of sustainability and inclusion.

Views expressed are personal

Not Separation, But Balance

India's secularism is not about distancing religion from public life, but about ensuring equal respect, coexistence and dignity for all faiths within a shared civic framework

In contemporary public discourse, the word secularism is invoked with great frequency, yet it is seldom defined with adequate clarity. The term often becomes a rhetorical instrument in political debates rather than a carefully understood philosophical concept. Much of this confusion arises from the fact that the idea of secularism has travelled across civilisations and historical contexts, acquiring different meanings in different societies. What is commonly described as secularism in the West is not identical to the idea that evolved in India. Indeed, the Indian conception of secularism represents a profoundly distinct civilizational philosophy—one that neither denies religion nor banishes it from public life, but instead creates a framework in which multiple faiths may coexist with dignity and mutual respect.

In the classical Western understanding, secularism is largely defined by the separation of church and state. This principle emerged from a particular historical experience marked by centuries of conflict between religious authority and political power. In Europe, the dominance of ecclesiastical institutions often intertwined governance with theology, leading to intense struggles over authority, doctrine, and political legitimacy. The eventual emergence of secular states in the West was therefore an attempt to disentangle political power from religious control, ensuring that governance would remain neutral in matters of faith. Consequently, Western secularism frequently came to be interpreted as the removal—or at least the minimisation—of religion from the public sphere.

India's historical trajectory, however, unfolded along a very different path. Unlike societies shaped by a single dominant church, India evolved as a vast civilizational mosaic where numerous religious traditions flourished simultaneously. Over millennia, the subcontinent became home to an extraordinary range of spiritual paths: Hinduism, Islam, Christianity, Sikhism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Zoroastrianism, among others. Each of these traditions found space to grow, interact, and influence the cultural life of the land. The Indian social order, therefore, never required the rigid separation of religion from public life; rather, it demanded a philosophy capable of accommodating diversity without descending into conflict.



Much confusion surrounding Indian secularism stems from the uncritical import of Western frameworks

From this historical experience emerged a uniquely Indian understanding of secularism. In India, secularism does not signify irreligion, nor does it imply hostility toward faith. Instead, it embodies the principle that the state must maintain principled equidistance from all religions, granting equal respect and protection to each. The role of the state is not to erase religious identity but to ensure that no single tradition receives undue privilege or discrimination. In this sense, Indian secularism is less about exclusion and more about harmonious coexistence.

At the heart of this philosophy lies an important distinction between tolerance and acceptance. Tolerance, though often praised as a virtue, carries within it a subtle condescension. To tolerate something is to endure it despite disagreement—to say, in effect, "I believe you are mistaken, yet I will allow your beliefs to exist." Acceptance, by contrast, represents a far more generous and profound moral attitude. Acceptance recognises that different traditions may embody their own valid insights into truth and spiritual experience. It acknowledges that the diversity of human belief is not merely something to be endured but something that enriches the collective wisdom of humanity.

Few thinkers have articulated this distinction with greater clarity than Swami Vivekananda. In his celebrated address at the World's Parliament of Religions, he proclaimed that the Indian spiritual tradition does not merely preach tolerance but "accepts all religions as true." These words were not a rhetorical flourish; they reflected the deeper philosophical ethos of the civilisation from which he emerged. Swami Vivekananda presented to the world a vision of religious plu-

ralism rooted not in reluctant coexistence but in genuine reverence for diversity. His message resonated profoundly because it expressed a civilizational truth that had long been embedded in the spiritual traditions of India.

Within this broader civilizational framework, Hinduism occupies a distinctive place. Unlike many religious systems founded upon a single prophet or unified doctrinal structure, Hindu thought developed organically over thousands of years. It encompasses an astonishing spectrum of philosophical schools, devotional practices, and spiritual disciplines. Within its expansive intellectual universe, one encounters rigorous metaphysical inquiry, fervent devotional worship, austere asceticism, and even strands of philosophical scepticism. The same tradition can accommodate the devotional poetry of saints, the metaphysical speculation of philosophers, the ritualistic practices of temple worship, and the contemplative silence of meditation.

This remarkable breadth gives Hinduism a uniquely accommodating character. It possesses the intellectual flexibility to embrace theism and atheism, personal devotion and abstract metaphysics, ritual practice and philosophical inquiry. Such plurality does not weaken the tradition; rather, it forms the very essence of its strength. The underlying intuition is that the ultimate truth may be approached through multiple paths, each reflecting the varied temperaments and experiences of human beings. In this sense, Hindu philosophy has historically fostered an environment where diversity of belief is not perceived as a threat but as a natural and enriching feature of spiritual life.

This pluralistic ethos also explains why India has historically served as a refuge for persecuted

communities. Across centuries, groups fleeing religious oppression elsewhere found sanctuary on Indian soil, where they were able to preserve their faith and traditions. The presence of diverse religious communities living side by side became an enduring feature of Indian civilisation, reinforcing the principle that coexistence was not only possible but profoundly enriching.

Therefore, the Indian idea of secularism must be understood not as the negation of religion but as the harmonious orchestration of many religions within a shared civic order. It is rooted in the recognition that spiritual diversity is a permanent feature of human society and that peace can only flourish when this diversity is acknowledged with respect and fairness. The state, in this framework, becomes a guardian of equality rather than an arbiter of belief. Ultimately, what makes India truly secular is not the absence of faith from its public life but the generous civilizational space it creates for many faiths to flourish together. It is a vision shaped by centuries of cultural interaction, philosophical reflection, and spiritual experimentation. The pluralistic spirit embedded in Hindu philosophy—and articulated so powerfully by thinkers like Swami Vivekananda—continues to illuminate this distinctive model of secularism.

In an age when societies across the world grapple with questions of identity, belief, and coexistence, the Indian experience offers an enduring lesson: that unity need not demand uniformity, and that a civilisation confident in its own foundations can embrace diversity without fear. True secularism, in this sense, is not the silencing of faith but the creation of a civic culture in which many faiths may live, grow, and contribute to the moral richness of the nation.

Views expressed are personal

'AN ATTEMPT TO SUPPORT A BANNED TERRORIST ORGANISATION'

India rejects Pakistan’s remarks on DeM case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India, on Wednesday, strongly rejected Pakistan’s statement criticising the sentencing of Kashmiri separatist leader Aasiya Andrabi and her associates, saying Islamabad has no locus standi to comment on India’s internal matters and judicial processes.

The Kashmiri separatist leader founded the all-female separatist group Dukhtaran-e-Millat (DeM) in Jammu and Kashmir. A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Delhi sentenced her to life in jail recently on allegations of terrorism, conspiracy, and waging war against India. Andrabi was arrested in April 2018 by the NIA for her role in inciting protests and violence in the Kashmir Valley.

She was charged with sedi-



MEA spokesman Randhir Jaiswal

FILE PIC

tion, criminal conspiracy, and inciting violence under the strict Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and the Indian Penal Code (IPC). The NIA charged her with inciting stone-throwing, receiving money from terror organisations in Pakistan (particularly mentioning Hafiz Saeed, the founder of Lashkar-e-Taiba),

and encouraging an armed uprising against India.

The Ministry of External Affairs described Pakistan’s remarks as an attempt to support a banned terrorist organisation and said such statements were consistent with its record of sponsoring terrorism. MEA spokesman Randhir Jaiswal said India categorically rejects

Highlights

- » MEA strongly rejected Pakistan’s statement criticising the sentencing of Kashmiri separatist leader Aasiya Andrabi and her associates
- » The Kashmiri separatist leader founded the all-female separatist group Dukhtaran-e-Millat (DeM) in Jammu and Kashmir
- » A special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court in Delhi sentenced her to life in jail recently on allegations of terrorism, conspiracy, and waging war against India

the statement issued by Pakistan in support of a banned terrorist organisation and its members. He stated that Pakistan has no right to interfere in matters that fall within India’s sovereign jurisdiction, including court proceedings conducted under Indian law.

He added that it was not surprising that a country with a long history of sponsoring terrorism had stated that, accord-

ing to India, condones violence and the killing of innocent people. The spokesman further said that instead of spreading what he termed false and frivolous narratives, Pakistan should reflect on its own record of serious and systematic human rights violations.

The Government of Pakistan also condemned the 30-year jail terms given to Fehmeeda Sofi and Nahida Nas-

reen. Pakistan termed the verdict a miscarriage of justice and alleged that the decision reflected suppression of fundamental rights in Jammu and Kashmir.

In its statement, Pakistan claimed that the sentencing was part of a broader pattern of politically motivated actions aimed at silencing dissent and raised concerns regarding due process, judicial independence and human rights. It also urged the international community, including the United Nations and global human rights organisations, to take note of the development and hold India accountable.

Pakistan further reiterated its support for the people of Jammu and Kashmir and called for the protection of their political and human rights, including the right to freedom of expression and a fair trial.

‘New criminal laws promise faster, fair resolution of cases’

NEW DELHI: The new criminal laws have introduced specific timelines for various stages of investigation and trial to ensure faster and fair resolution of cases, the Centre has informed the Lok Sabha.

Replying to a question by BJP MP Anil Baluni, Minister of State for Home Bandi Sanjay Kumar on Tuesday said the new laws -- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023 -- promise a faster and fair resolution of cases, instilling confidence in the legal system.

Baluni had sought details of the time limits prescribed for procedures in the three laws.

According to the minister, preliminary inquiry in a case is to be completed within 14 days, while further investigation must be concluded within 90 days. The supply of documents, including FIR and related records, to both the victim and the accused has to be ensured within 14 days.

He said commitment of cases for trial is to take place within 90 days, while discharge applications and framing of charges are required to be completed within 60 days each. Judgments are to be pronounced within 45 days, and timelines have also been prescribed for mercy petitions -- 30 days before the governor and 60 days before the President, Kumar added.

The minister said the new laws place special emphasis on crimes against women and children, with investigations in such cases required to be completed within two months of recording of information. In cases of sexual assault, medical practitioners are mandated to send the medical examination report of the victim to the investigating officer within seven days, he said.

Kumar also said courts

can grant a maximum of two adjournments during hearings to prevent unnecessary delays and ensure timely delivery of justice.

Highlighting victim-centric provisions, he said victims are entitled to get update on the progress of their case within 90 days. This provision keeps victims informed and involved in the legal process, enhancing transparency and trust, he added.

Preliminary inquiry in a case is to be completed within 14 days, while further investigation must be concluded within 90 days

The minister said that offences against women and children have been given precedence in the new legal framework.

Kumar said the laws also leverage technology to improve efficiency, including provisions for online reporting of offences, electronic registration of FIRs, and issuance of summons through electronic means.

He said to strengthen the cases and investigations, it has become mandatory for forensic experts to visit crime scenes for serious offences and collect evidence in offences which are punishable for seven years or more. Additionally, the process of evidence collection at the crime scene will be mandatorily videographed to prevent tampering of evidence.

All legal proceedings can also be conducted in electronic mode, which is expected to reduce delays and improve accessibility for victims, witnesses and the accused, he added.

Mahadev app: ED attaches assets worth about Rs 1,700 cr in Dubai

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) attached fresh immovable assets worth about Rs 1,700 crore located in Dubai belonging to entities linked to Sourabh Chandrakar, one of the main promoters of the “illegal” Mahadev online betting app, as part of its money laundering investigation, sources said on Wednesday.

The federal probe agency earlier said that the case involves various high-ranking politicians and bureaucrats from Chhattisgarh.

Sources said that the ED regional office located in Chhattisgarh capital Raipur has issued a provisional order under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) to attach multiple villas and costly houses, including some located in Burj

INSIGHT

- » The case involves various high-ranking politicians and bureaucrats from Chhattisgarh
- » Sources said that the ED regional office in Raipur has issued a provisional order under the PMLA to attach multiple villas and costly houses, including some located in Burj Khalifa

Khalifa, the world’s tallest building located in Dubai.

The attached properties are understood to be linked to Chandrakar, connected com-

panies and associates, according to sources. A few assets attached under the latest order are located in India, they said.

The Mahadev app was promoted by Chandrakar and his associate Ravi Uppal, both of whom hail from Chhattisgarh.

India is pursuing their extradition. While the last known location of Chandrakar was in the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Uppal is stated to have fled to Vanuatu from the UAE. Chandrakar and others allegedly “cheated” the public through the Mahadev app that was created to facilitate multiple illegal betting websites or mobile applications to acquire customers and take care of the financial operations for these illegal betting games and websites.

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini met Russian Ambassador to India Denis Alipov at his residence in Chandigarh on Wednesday to discuss avenues for strengthening bilateral cooperation.

The meeting focused on enhancing economic engagement between Haryana and Russia, with emphasis on boosting exports from the state.

Saini highlighted Haryana’s strengths in sectors such as IT, automobiles, agro-processing, textiles and manufacturing, stating that the state is well-positioned to cater to the Russian market. Both sides discussed measures to ease trade flows, address logistical chal-



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini during a meeting with Russian Ambassador to India Denis Alipov and others at his residence in Chandigarh

MPOST

lenges and improve market access, while also exploring investment opportunities.

The leaders also stressed the importance of structured partnerships between Haryana and Russian regions. They agreed on promoting direct business-to-business inter-

actions, exchange visits by industry representatives and organising joint forums to foster long-term collaborations.

Alipov appreciated Haryana’s MSME sector, noting its key role in industrial growth and employment generation.

Haryana: PMC detects major FDR ‘discrepancies’

MPOST BUREAU

TAKEAWAYS

- » Deposits held at Panchkula Sector 11 branch of Kotak Mahindra Bank
- » Opposition demands high-level probe and accountability
- » Discrepancy surfaced when the civic body sought withdrawal of FDs on maturity

CHANDIGARH: An alleged fraud of around Rs 150 crore has surfaced at the Panchkula branch of Kotak Mahindra Bank, after the Panchkula Municipal Corporation detected major discrepancies in its fixed deposit (FD) accounts.

According to officials, the municipal corporation had opened an account at the bank’s Sector 11 branch, where 16 fixed deposits were being maintained. The issue came to light when the corporation approached the bank to redeem its FDs upon maturity. In response, the bank informed officials that details of five deposits were not traceable, raising alarm within the civic body.

Following this, authorities swiftly constituted an inquiry committee comprising senior officials, includ-

ing the Accounts Officer and the Commissioner. The committee conducted a preliminary probe and submitted its report to both the bank and the Haryana government, flagging serious inconsistencies.

Subsequently, the matter was escalated, and on March 24, the Chief Secretary’s office wrote to the Director General of Police of the State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (SVACB), seeking a thorough investigation into the alleged irregularities.

Amid growing concerns,

the bank issued an official statement stating that it has initiated a detailed reconciliation of fixed deposits and linked accounts maintained by the municipal corporation. It maintained that, based on records examined so far, all processes, documentation, and transactions related to the accounts were handled in accordance with due norms. The bank also confirmed that it has filed a formal complaint with the Panchkula Police.

This development marks the second major banking-related controversy in Hary-

ana this year, following the Rs 590-crore fraud case involving IDFC First Bank.

Reacting sharply to the incident, former Haryana Chief Minister and Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda alleged large-scale misappropriation of public funds. He claimed that such a massive fraud would not have been possible without official collusion and demanded a high-level probe into the matter.

Hooda further accused the ruling government of failing on governance and alleged that multiple scams, including irregularities in agricultural procurement schemes, have surfaced in recent times. He said the Panchkula case reflects a broader pattern of financial mismanagement and called for accountability to ensure public money is safeguarded.

POCSO CASE Swami Avimukteshwaranand gets anticipatory bail

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday granted anticipatory bail to Swami Avimukteshwaranand Saraswati and his disciple Mukundanand Brahmachari in a case registered against them under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act.

The order was passed by Justice Jitendra Kumar Sinha on the anticipatory bail applications moved by the seer and his disciple.

However, the court restrained both the first informant and the applicants from making any statements before the media in this regard.

Earlier on February 27, the court had stayed the arrest of Avimukteshwaranand, directing that he would not be taken into custody till the pronouncement of the order in the matter related to alleged sexual harassment of minor children and other offences.

The court had also reserved its order after hearing the matter and directed the applicants to cooperate with the investigation.

The case pertains to an FIR lodged at the Jhansi police station in Prayagraj following directions from a POCSO court, alleging sexual exploitation of several ‘batuks’ (young disciples) by the accused.

During the last hearing, Justice Sinha had also directed the state government and the complainant, Ashutosh Pandey alias Ashutosh Brahmchari, to file their replies.

Avimukteshwaranand had maintained that the allegations were fabricated, while the complainant had hoped justice would be served after the evidence was submitted in court.

The defence had argued that the complainant has a criminal history and that the seer has been falsely implicated, also claiming that the alleged victims never stayed at his ashram.

The state had opposed the plea on technical grounds, saying it was filed directly in the high court without first approaching a sessions court.



NR defeats CR to win All India Rly Women Hockey Championship

KAPURTHALA: Northern Railway emerged champions of the 46th All India Railway Women Hockey Championship, defeating Central Railway 2-0 in a thrilling final held at the Rail Coach Factory (RCF) in Kapurthala on Wednesday.

Northern Railway took the lead early in the contest, with Kanika Siwach scoring a field goal in the 14th minute. The team consolidated its advantage in the 49th minute when Manju converted a penalty corner to seal a comfortable 2-0 victory. Despite the loss, Central Railway’s Divya Thepe was adjudged Player of the Final for her impressive performance.

In the third-place playoff, hosts RCF Kapurthala edged past South Eastern Railway, Kolkata 1-0. Annu netted the decisive goal through a penalty



stroke in the 54th minute to secure a podium finish for the home side.

The championship witnessed participation from nine teams representing various Zonal Railways and Production Units. The teams were divided into two pools, with top performers advancing to the semifinals. Central Railway and South Eastern Railway progressed from Pool A, while Northern Railway and

RCF Kapurthala qualified from Pool B. Northern Railway and Central Railway eventually advanced to the final after winning their respective semifinals.

At the closing ceremony, former international hockey player Rajbir Kaur presented awards to the winners and outstanding players. Lal Thant Luangi of RCF Kapurthala was named Player of the Championship and received a cash prize of Rs 11,000.

MPOST

‘Antibiotic resistance fuels 87% of India’s typhoid economic burden’

Total economic burden due to typhoid fever estimated at Rs 123 billion

NEW DELHI: Antibiotic-resistant typhoid infections accounted for at least 87 per cent of India’s disease-related economic burden in 2023, according to a study in The Lancet Regional Health Southeast Asia.

The total economic burden due to typhoid fever was estimated at Rs 123 billion.

Children under the age of 10 incurred the highest economic burden, contributing to over half of the costs, researchers, including those from London School of Hygiene and Tropical Medicine and Christian Medical College in Vellore, found.

They also estimated that households bore 91 per cent of expenses, and 70,000 families faced “catastrophic” health expenditure.

Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh (including Telangana), Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal were estimated to account for 51 per cent of the national costs.

Typhoid fever is an infectious disease commonly transmitted through contaminated food or water. Symptoms can include



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

KEY POINTS

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- » Researchers also estimated that households bore 91 per cent of expenses, and

70,000 families faced ‘catastrophic’ health expenditure

- » Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh (including Telangana), Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal were estimated to account for 51 per cent of the national costs

high fever, fatigue, headache and stomach pain.

The authors said the findings provide key evidence to support the introduction of the typhoid conjugate vaccine in the national immunisation schedule, which is under consideration, the authors said.

Evidence from the study also

supports enhancing antibiotic resistance control and guiding national health financing policies, they said.

The researchers analysed empirical data from India on typhoid epidemiology, care-seeking, clinical outcomes, and estimated direct and indirect costs for hospitalised and non-hos-

pitalised typhoid fever patients.

“Typhoid fever imposes a significant economic burden in India, shaped by fluoroquinolone resistance, children less than ten years of age, and high-burden provincial states of the country, resulting in considerable household financial strain,” the authors wrote.

“Fluoroquinolone-resistant infections accounted for 87 per cent of total costs,” they said.

The antibiotic fluoroquinolone helps treat severe infections and is said to be highly effective in reducing fever in typhoid within four days.

The authors said available evidence on the economic burden of typhoid fever is fragmented and geographically limited. The study presents a comprehensive, nationally representative estimate, they said.

The analysis also indicated that fluoroquinolone-resistant infections drive the economic burden of typhoid fever in India, disproportionately affecting young children and placing a significant financial burden on families, the team said.

AGENCIES

Fugitive Punjab MLA arrested from Gwalior

CHANDIGARH: AAP MLA Harmet Singh Pathanmajra was arrested by the Punjab Police from Madhya Pradesh’s Gwalior, more than six months after he escaped police custody in a rape case.

Officials on Wednesday said that Pathanmajra, a first-time MLA from Sanour in Patiala, was nabbed along with his three associates from the outskirts of the Gwalior area late Tuesday night. He was produced before a court in Patiala, which sent him to a four-day police remand.

On September 1, 2025, the police registered a case against Pathanmajra on charges of rape, cheating and criminal intimidation, based on a complaint by a Zirakpur-based woman, who alleged that the MLA misrepresented himself as a divorcee, entered into a relationship with her and tied the knot in 2021 while already being married.

She accused him of continued sexual exploitation and threats.

MPOST

'OFFERS ISLAMABAD AS A VENUE FOR THE PURPOSE'

Pakistan channels Iran-US messages amid rising West Asia tensions

LAHORE: Pakistan is relaying messages between Iran and the US with the aim to help de-escalate the West Asia conflict, a top government official said on Wednesday.

"We are trying to broker US-Iran peace talks and have also offered Islamabad as a venue for the purpose. But it will be possible if Iran agrees to sit at the table with America," a top official in the Shehbaz Sharif administration said on the condition of anonymity.

"At the moment, Pakistan is relaying messages between the US and Iran. Islamabad not only handed over the 15-point proposal of the US to Iran but also Tehran's demands to the Trump administration to ink a peace deal," he said.

The 15-point proposal outlines strict conditions targeting Iran's nuclear and regional policies in exchange for major sanctions relief, he added.

Under the proposal, Iran would be required to fully dismantle its nuclear programme and commit never to pursuing nuclear weapons. All enriched nuclear material would be transferred to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)



The war has raged on with no let-up in air attacks against Iran

PIC/THE WHITE HOUSE

within an agreed timeframe.

Key nuclear facilities, including the Natanz Nuclear Facility, Isfahan Nuclear Technology Centre and Fordow Fuel Enrichment Plant, would be decommissioned and destroyed under the plan. The IAEA would also be granted full access to all aspects of Iran's nuclear programme, he said, speaking about the proposal.

The proposal further calls on Iran to cease funding, directing and arming allied

groups across the region, a longstanding point of contention with both Washington and Israel, he added. In a move aimed at safeguarding global energy supplies, the plan ensures that the Strait of Hormuz will remain open as a free maritime route, preventing any disruption to international shipping.

As a final decision on Iran's missile programme has been deferred, the proposal says any future arrangement would

impose limits on the range and number of missiles, restricting their use to defensive purposes only. In return, the United States is prepared to lift all sanctions on Iran and support the development of a civilian nuclear programme, including assistance at the Bushehr facility, the official informed.

The proposal also includes removing the so-called "snapback" mechanism, which allows for the automatic reimposition of United Nations

In Short

- » "Islamabad not only handed over the 15-point proposal of the US to Iran but also Tehran's demands to the Trump administration to ink a peace deal," an official said
- » The 15-point proposal outlines strict conditions targeting Iran's nuclear and regional policies in exchange for major sanctions relief, he added.

Asia leans on COVID-era fix to address growing fuel crunch

Nations scrambling to respond to fuel shortages

SEOUL: Countries across Asia are weighing up work-from-home policies and stimulus measures enforced during the COVID pandemic, as they scramble to respond to global fuel shortages triggered by the Iran war.

Asia is at the frontline of the fuel crisis, buying more than 80% of the crude that transits the Strait of Hormuz, which has been almost totally blocked by Iran since the war broke out on February 28.

No country in the region has enforced work-from-home measures yet, but some have said they are on the table.

"I think it is a good idea," South Korean Energy Minister Kim Sung-whan said on Tuesday when asked about an International Energy Agency recommendation for people to work from home.

The IEA, which agreed a record release of around 400 million barrels of oil from strategic stockpiles to deal with the crisis, has outlined proposals to ease oil price pressures such as working from home and avoiding air travel. IEA Executive Director Fatih Birol repeated those calls at a conference in Sydney this week. "There were real-life tests, such as after the



People queue up at a petrol pump in large numbers in Hyderabad

PTI

No country in the region has enforced work-from-home measures yet

Russian invasion of Ukraine, European countries adopted these measures, and it was announced by the European governments. It helped them a lot to go through these difficult times without Russian energy," Birol said.

Industrial powerhouse South Korea on Tuesday launched a public campaign asking people to cut shower time, charge phones during the day and run vacuums on week-

ends. "We will consult with relevant ministries and actively consider measures for work-from-home," Energy Minister Kim told a briefing.

The Philippines, which relies heavily on Middle Eastern oil for its energy needs, shortened the work week in some government offices earlier this month. President Ferdinand Marcos declared a state of national energy emergency saying the conflict poses an "imminent danger" to the country's energy supply.

Pakistan closed schools for two weeks and said office workers would work more from home. Sri Lanka declared a public holiday every Wednesday to help make its fuel supplies go further.

AGENCIES

SENDS OVER NEARLY 400 DRONES

Kyiv replies to Russian drone barrage

MOSCOW: Russian air defences downed 389 incoming Ukrainian drones, Russia's Defence Ministry said Wednesday, in what was the largest reported overnight attack on Russian regions and Crimea since Moscow's forces invaded Ukraine more than four years ago.

The drones were stopped over 13 Russian regions as well as the Crimean Peninsula, which Russia illegally annexed from Ukraine in 2014.

The attack underlined the growing capability of Ukraine's domestically developed and manufactured long-range drones. It came a day after Russia fired almost 1,000 drones and 34 missiles at civilian areas of Ukraine in the space of 24 hours, extending its usual nighttime barrage into daylight hours in one of its biggest aerial attacks of the war.

At least six people were killed and around 50 people were injured, Ukrainian authorities said.

The United Nations cultural organization UNESCO on Wednesday said it was "deeply



Rescue workers try to put out a fire in Ukraine's Odesa

AP/PTI

The drones were stopped over 13 Russian regions as well as Crimea

alarmed" by Russia hitting a World Heritage site in the western Ukraine city of Lviv during that bombardment.

The escalation in aerial attacks comes amid a pause in US-mediated talks between delegations from Moscow and Kyiv, as Washington's attention is diverted by the Iran war and

as Ukraine anticipates a spring offensive by Russia's bigger army.

Alexander Drozdenko, governor of the Leningrad region north of Moscow, said 56 drones were shot down there, and a fire broke out in the Baltic Sea port of Ust-Luga as the result of Ukraine's attack.

Ukrainian forces also carried out a missile strike on the Belgorod region on the border with Ukraine overnight, damaging energy infrastructure, its Gov. Vyacheslav Gladkov said. Power, water and heating supplies were disrupted, he said.

AGENCIES

US may send more soldiers to Middle East

WASHINGTON: The Pentagon is expected to send thousands of soldiers from the U.S. Army's elite 82nd Airborne Division to the Middle East, two people familiar with the matter told Reuters on Tuesday, adding to a massive U.S. military buildup even as President Donald Trump talks about a possible deal with Tehran to end the war.

It was reported on March 18 that Trump's administration was considering deploying thousands of additional U.S. troops, a move that would expand options to include deployment of forces inside Iranian territory. Such an escalation could dramatically raise the stakes in the conflict, which is already in its fourth week and has roiled global markets.

The officials, speaking on the condition of anonymity, did not specify where in the Middle East the troops would go or when they would arrive in the region. The soldiers are stationed at Fort Bragg, North Carolina. The U.S. military referred questions to the White House, which said all announcements on troop deployments would come from the Pentagon.

"As we have said, President Trump always has all military options at his disposal," White House spokeswoman Anna Kelly said. No decision had been made to send troops into Iran itself, one of the sources told Reuters, adding but they will build up capacity for potential future operations in the region.

AGENCIES

Double standards of Israel over nuclear power?

Wants to destroy Iran's nuclear plan but what about its own

QUEENSLAND: Israel's avowed goal in the Middle East war is to prevent Iran from acquiring nuclear weapons. Yet, the double standard associated with this is hardly sustainable in the long run.

The worst-kept secret in the world of nuclear politics is that Israel possesses a formidable arsenal of nuclear weapons. It began developing these in the 1950s and reached a fully operational capability by the late 1960s.

Although Israel refuses to confirm or deny this fact, arms control organisations have assessed that the country has some 80-90 nuclear weapons.

In recent days, Iran targeted Israel's nuclear facility in the southern town of Dimona, injuring more than 100 people. The head of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) called for restraint to avoid a "nuclear accident".

Shrouded in secrecy

There is much evidence to support the existence of Israel's arsenal. In 1963, then-Deputy Defence Minister Shimon Peres famously stated Israel would not be the first to "introduce" nuclear weapons to the Middle East.

What this actually meant was spelled out a few years later

Summary

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- » Although Israel refuses to confirm or deny this fact, arms control organisations have assessed that the country has some 80-90 nuclear weapons

by the Israeli ambassador to the US. For a weapon to be "introduced", he said, it needed to be tested and publicly declared. Merely possessing them did not constitute introducing them.

Several whistleblower accounts, intelligence reports and satellite imagery confirm the extent of the Israeli programme and its capabilities.

More recently, Amichai Eliyahu, a far-right minister in Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government, alluded to using nuclear weapons in Gaza - a tacit acknowledgement of Israel's capabilities. He was later reprimanded by Netanyahu.

AGENCIES



ATTENTION! GST TAXPAYERS

Whose Aggregate Annual Turnover[#] is upto a specified limit* can opt for GST Composition Scheme for the FY 2026-2027 by 31st March, 2026

Eligible taxpayers who wish to avail the Composition Scheme can follow these steps on the GST portal (www.gst.gov.in):



Log in to the Taxpayers' Interface



Go to Services > Registration > Application to Opt for Composition Levy



Fill the FORM GST CMP-02 and submit

Those eligible taxpayers, who are already availing Composition Scheme, need not file FORM CMP-02 if they are eligible.



Easy & Convenient Compliance



Attractive Tax Rates



Minimum Compliance Requirements



Auto Continuation/Renewal and Easy to Opt-out



Available for supplier of Goods as well as Services



Less Bookkeeping

* Type of Suppliers		# Aggregate Annual Turnover during FY 2025-26
Supplier of Goods	Taxpayers registered in 08 Specified States	upto ₹75 Lakh
	Taxpayers registered in other States	upto ₹150 Lakh
Supplier of Services		upto ₹50 Lakh

For more details, please refer to section 10 of CGST Act, Rule 3-7 of CGST Rules and Notification No. 14/2019 - Central Tax dated 07.03.2019

GST Composition Scheme: Big Benefits for Small Taxpayers

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CBC 15502/13/0051/2526

AIMS TO EXPAND REGIONAL AVIATION

Cabinet clears revamped UDAN scheme with Rs 28,840 cr outlay

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Revamping the regional air connectivity initiative, the Union Cabinet on Wednesday cleared a modified UDAN scheme with an outlay of Rs 28,840 crore for ten years that will provide funds for developing airports, related operations and maintenance activities, helipads and support for acquisition of India-made aircraft.

Airlines will be provided Viability Gap Funding (VGF) for operating UDAN routes, and the amount is estimated to be Rs 10,043 crore over the ten-year period starting from FY 2026-27.

Briefing media persons after the Cabinet meeting, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that under the modified scheme, 100 airports would be developed from existing unserved airstrips with the help of state governments, and the outlay in this regard would be Rs 12,159 crore over the next eight years.

Chhattisgarh DISCOM earns 'A' rating in national power rankings

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: The Ministry of Power has released the 2026 ranking and rating of 54 power distribution companies (DISCOMs) across the country, with the Chhattisgarh State Power Distribution Company Limited (CSPDCL) securing an 'A' rating for improved consumer services and operational efficiency.

The upgrade marks a significant improvement from its previous 'B' grade in the 13th Annual Integrated Rating and Ranking of Power Distribution Utilities. CSPDCLs score rose from 54.41 to 70.40 points, reflecting a gain of over 16 points.

Officials attributed the achievement to better administrative efficiency, strengthened management practices, and sustained corrective measures in power distribution, financial stability and consumer service delivery.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai, his secretary Subodh Kumar Singh, and Energy Secretary Dr Rohit Yadav congratulated the officers and employees of CSPDCL for the performance.

Managing Director Bhim Singh Kanwar said the improved rating underscores the utility's commitment to reforms and service quality. He added that focused efforts in operational improvements and financial discipline had contributed to the enhanced performance.

The annual ranking by the Ministry of Power assesses utilities on parameters including operational efficiency, financial sustainability and consumer services, providing a benchmark for performance across states.



core over the next eight years.

The scheme aims to develop 200 modern helipads at Rs 15 crore each, amounting to a total requirement of Rs 3,661 crore over the next eight years (inflation-adjusted), an official release said.

The focus will be to develop helipads in priority and aspirational districts to improve last-mile connectivity and emergency response.

Towards Operation & Maintenance (O&M) works, the scheme will provide support for three years, capped at Rs 3.06 crore per annum per airport and Rs 0.90 crore per annum per heliport/water aerodrome. The total amount is estimated to be Rs 2,577 crore for around 441 aerodromes, the release said.

According to the government, the funding is being pro-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Under the modified scheme, 100 airports would be developed from existing unserved airstrips with the help of state govts, and the outlay in this regard would be Rs 12,159 crore over the next eight yrs

» Scheme aims to develop 200 modern helipads at Rs 15 crore each: Govt

Dhruv helicopters for Pawan Hans and two HAL Dornier aircraft for Alliance Air," the release said.

The modified UDAN (Ude Desh ka Aam Nagrik) scheme has been approved for the period from FY2026-27 to FY 2035-36 with a total outlay of Rs 28,840 crore, and there will be budgetary support from the central government.

The existing UDAN scheme ends later this year.

Since the launch of UDAN in October 2016, the government said 663 routes have been operationalised across 95 airports, heliports and water aerodromes. These figures are till February 28.

More than 3.41 lakh flights have been operated, carrying 162.47 lakh passengers under the scheme, which has fostered growth in regional airlines and diverse fleet operations, it added.

India is one of the world's fastest-growing domestic civil aviation markets.

posed, given the high recurring O&M costs and limited revenue streams for the Regional Connectivity Scheme (RCS)-only aerodromes.

"To address the shortage of small fixed-wing aircraft and helicopters required for operations in remote and difficult terrains and to advance the Atmanirbhar Bharat vision, the scheme also proposes to procure two HAL

Central govt asks states to fast-track gas pipeline approvals, mandates shift to PNG where available

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The central government, on Wednesday, said that it has asked states and Union Territories to expedite approvals required for the expansion of gas pipeline networks. Stressing the change in the cooking fuel patterns of millions of households, the centre has ordered that LPG supply will be cut off if consumers fail to switch to piped natural gas where it is available.

In a recent notification issued under the Essential Commodities Act, the government has introduced a new order to provide a time-bound framework for laying and expanding natural gas and petroleum pipelines. Officials said the move is expected to accelerate PNG connectivity, improve last-mile supply and strengthen energy security.



Piped Natural Gas is not produced separately — it comes from natural gas extracted from oil and gas fields or imported LNG that is regasified and supplied through pipelines. Furthermore, PNG is supplied through the City Gas Distribution (CGD) network - which allows continuous supply. Once pipelines are laid, the PNG supply is more stable compared to LPG.

Amid the rising West Asia conflict, causing uncertainty

Market rally adds Rs 15.80L cr to investor wealth in two days

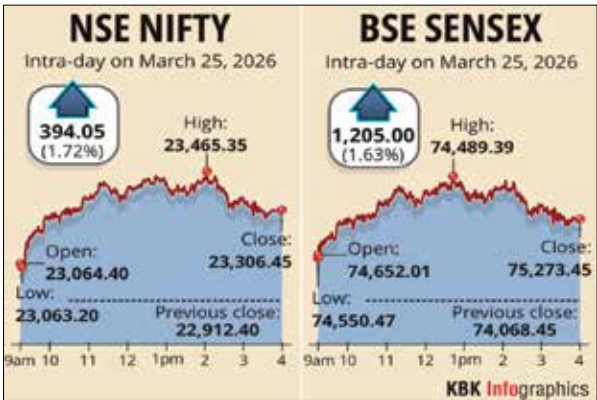
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With a rebound in the stock market, investors' wealth have surged by Rs 15.80 lakh crore in two days following a sharp decline in crude oil prices and hopes of de-escalation in the West Asia war.

Stock markets have been rallying for the past two trading days, with the BSE Sensex climbing 2,577.06 points or 3.54 per cent. On Wednesday, the 30-share BSE benchmark jumped 1,205 points or 1.63 per cent to settle at 75,273.45.

Thanks to optimism in investors' sentiment, the market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies climbed Rs 15,80,204.92 crore to Rs 4,31,01,834.74 crore (USD 4.59 trillion) in two days.

"Indian equities extended their recovery for the second consecutive session, supported by improving global cues and emerging hopes of a potential de-escalation in the ongoing US-Iran conflict," Siddhartha Khemka - Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tanked 6.16 per cent to USD 97.79 per barrel.



"Markets continued to build on the previous day's momentum as global risk sentiment improved, with hopes of peace emerging on the radar. Potential diplomatic progress between the US and Iran—despite mixed geopolitical commentary — led to easing crude oil prices below USD100, which was welcomed by the market," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended higher. Markets in Europe were trading in

the positive territory.

From the 30-Sensex firms, UltraTech Cement, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, Titan, InterGlobe Aviation and Trent were the biggest gainers on Wednesday.

Tech Mahindra, Power Grid, Tata Consultancy Services and Bharat Electronics were the laggards.

The BSE SmallCap Select index jumped 3.05 per cent and MidCap Select index climbed 2.50 per cent.

All sectoral indices rose, led by private banks, commodities and PSU banks. Markets extended gains for a second day on easing tensions and lower crude; 2,959 stocks advanced.

Tata Power completes UP transmission proj

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Tata Power on Wednesday said it has commissioned two transmission lines in Uttar Pradesh, completing all extra high voltage (EHV) infrastructure under the South East UP Power Transmission Company Limited (SEUP-PTCL) project.

The newly operational lines — 400 kV Tanda-Gonda and 400 kV Gonda-Basti double circuit — span 154 circuit kilometres. With this, the SEUP-PTCL network comprises three 765 kV lines (951 km), 14 400 kV lines (566 km), and three 765/400 kV substations with a combined transformation capacity of 3,460 MVA.

The commissioning of four key assets, including the 765 kV Mainpuri-Bara and Mainpuri-Unnao single circuit lines along with the two 400 kV lines, is expected to facilitate evacuation of over 4,000 MW of ther-

Adds 154 km of transmission lines

mal power generated within the state. The infrastructure is aimed at supporting rising electricity demand and improving grid stability.

SEUPPTCL is part of Resurgent Power Ventures Pte Limited, a joint venture led by Tata Power with participation from ICICI Bank and other investors. The project was acquired through the resolution of stressed power assets.

The transmission network was built with over 45,000 metric tonnes of tower steel and more than 8,600 km of conductors, and involved 139 crossings, including railway tracks, highways and rivers.

With these additions, Tata Power's operational transmission network has reached 5,466 circuit kilometres.

PFC highlights AI-driven power tech at Bharat Electricity Summit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Power Finance Corporation showcased a range of digital and grid management technologies at the Bharat Electricity Summit (BES) 2026, highlighting its role beyond financing in supporting power sector modernisation.

The state-run lender presented artificial intelligence-driven and indigenous solutions aimed at improving power distribution, reliability and last-mile connectivity. Among the key technologies on display were an integrated SCADA-ADMS-OMS platform, GeoAI-based asset mapping and real-time fault detection systems.

Officials said these tools are designed to help utilities



enhance operational efficiency and strengthen grid resilience, particularly as electricity demand continues to rise.

PFC also highlighted its National SCADA Resource Centre, which focuses on capacity building and training for power distribution companies. A micro substation model, aimed at providing low-cost solutions for last-mile electrification, was also exhibited.

The company said the initiatives are aligned with efforts to modernise distribution infrastructure under ongoing reform programmes and improve service delivery across states. Senior government representatives, including Union ministers overseeing power and renewable energy, visited the pavilion during the event and reviewed the technologies on display.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Power Ministry is believed to have directed imported coal-based thermal plants to operate at full capacity for three months from April 1, to avoid any electricity shortage amid the estimated peak demand of 270GW during this summer.

Sources said that in letters sent to imported coal-based plants in the country, the power ministry invoked Section 11 of the Electricity Act, asking them to run at full capacity.

The step has been taken to ensure optimal power availability, considering the prevailing demand-supply scenario and the expected rise in electricity demand in the coming months,

'The order shall remain valid for the generation and supply of power from April 1, 2026, to June 30, 2026'

according to the letter.

The ministry has estimated the peak power demand to be over 270GW during this summer season (April onwards).

However, during last summer (April 2025 onwards), the peak power demand was 242.77 GW in June, 2025.

According to government estimates, peak power demand was expected to touch 277 GW in the summer of 2025.

The peak power demand touched an all-time high of about 250 GW in May 2024. The previous all-time peak

power demand of 243.27 GW was recorded in September 2023. The peak power demand met or the highest supply during February rose slightly to 243.15 GW from 238.06 GW recorded in February 2025.

There are about 15 imported coal-based thermal power projects in the country which have got this directive from the power ministry, the sources said. The order shall remain valid for the generation and supply of power from April 1, 2026, to June 30, 2026, they further stated. Earlier this

month, Tata Power arm Coastal Gujarat Power Ltd (CGPL), which operates the 4000 MW Mundra plant, informed about signing supplementary power purchase agreements (PPA) with GUVNL (Gujarat).

The plant supplies 50 per cent of the output to Gujarat. The company will ink supplementary PPAs with Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Punjab, and Haryana subsequently.

The 4,000 MW Mundra Ultra Mega Power Project in Kutch, Gujarat, remained shut after operations at all five 800 MW units were suspended on July 2, 2025, leading to losses. The coal-based plant supplies power to Gujarat, Maharashtra, Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan.

1/3 Indian PC users faced offline cyber attack in '25; over 6.4 crore incidents blocked: Kaspersky

Attackers use fake Teams & Drive apps to target unsuspecting users

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Disconnecting from the internet does not guarantee safety from cyber threats, as nearly one in three computer users in India were targeted by local, on-device attacks in 2025, according to a report by cybersecurity major Kaspersky.

The company stated it detected and blocked over 6.46 crore local incidents in India between January and December 2025.

These threats were primarily delivered through offline sources such as USB drives and other removable media,



placing India among the top 80 most affected countries globally for local cyber threat exposure.

According to the data from Kaspersky Security Network (KSN), 29.8 per cent of users in

9.8% of users in the country encountered these offline threats, with worms and file viruses accounting for a significant share of the attacks

are persistent in exploiting the removable devices and tools people rely on every day. In 2025, our researchers even found out that attackers are mimicking popular collaboration tools like Micro-

soft Teams and Google Drive to trick users into downloading malware, ultimately stealing login credentials, banking information, and sensitive personal data," said Adrian Hia, Managing Director for Asia Pacific at Kaspersky.

Global detection systems also recorded a massive 59 per cent surge in password stealers and a 51 per cent increase in spyware detections.

In the Asia Pacific region specifically, Hia noted a considerable increase in malicious files designed to remotely execute commands and harvest confidential data from victims' devices.

NEW DELHI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said the Union Budget has taken several "facilitative" measures for the middle class and MSMEs, and the government is moving forward with reforms not out of compulsion, but with conviction and clarity.

Replying to the debate on Finance Bill 2026 in the Lok Sabha, Sitharaman said the fiscal deficit is projected to come down to 4.3 per cent of GDP in FY27, from 9.3 per cent in FY21, and the country's debt-to-GDP ratio is on a declining path and is lower than most major economies.

The Lok Sabha passed the Finance Bill 2026, by a voice vote after including 32 government amendments.



The Finance Bill, 2026, Sitharaman said rests on five key principles -- trust-based tax administration; ease of living for citizens; empowering farmers, MSMEs and cooperatives; making India stronger global business hub; and seamless trade facilitation and customs reforms. Rejecting opposition charge that the middle class have been left out in the Budget for 2026-27 fiscal year, the minister listed out measures like reduction in TCS rate on payments made under Liberalised

Remittance Scheme (LRS) for foreign education and medical treatment. Also, TCS on overseas tour packages have been slashed to 2 per cent from 20 per cent earlier.

She also said the Finance Bill provided for exempting customs duty on 17 critical drugs and duty-free import of medicines and personal use.

Besides, to make life easier for taxpayers, the facility to file updated I-T returns have been allowed even where reassessment proceedings have been initiated, and a foreign asset disclosure scheme for small taxpayers have been brought in. To reduce disputes at airports with customs officers, the Bill provides for rationalising tariffs on gifts and items brought into India. AGENCIES

Impact rule faces impact

Majority of IPL captains express reservations on Impact Player rule

NEW DELHI: A majority of IPL captains on Wednesday expressed their reservations on the Impact Player rule that has divided opinions since its introduction in 2023.

In 2024, the BCCI had extended the Impact Player in the IPL until at least 2027. Yet, the strategic rule continues to be debated by fans and players alike.

In the IPL Captains Meeting in Mumbai, the topic was discussed at length by the leaders of all 10 franchises.

"Majority of the captains gave their inputs on the Impact Player rule and expressed their reservations even though the BCCI has extended the rule till 2027. They were told it can only be reviewed after the 2027 edition and not before that," an IPL source told PTI.

Earlier this week, Delhi Capitals skipper Axar Patel joined the likes of Rohit Sharma in criticising the Impact Player rule. "I don't like this rule as I am an all-rounder myself. Earlier we used to pick all-rounders for this role (batting and bowling). Now the team management goes with a particular batter or bowler, they say why do we need an all-rounder?"

"Being an all-rounder myself I don't like it but at the same time rules are rules.



DC captain Axar Patel with MI counterpart Hardik Pandya, RR's Riyan Parag and SRH's Ishan Kishan

We have to follow them. But personally I don't like it," said Axar on Monday in his opening media interaction ahead of IPL 2026.

In 2024, Rohit had said that he was not a fan of the Impact Player concept saying it hampered the development of all-rounders in Indian cricket while the following season, Hardik Pandya said it had become difficult to pick an all-rounder in the side unless he was equally good with both bat and ball.

Even foreign players like Glenn Phillips have said that

the rule could adversely impact the future of all-rounders.

"I do feel like there could be an issue at some stage with all-rounders losing out and not being so prevalent, which then obviously has an impact on international game, international T20s, international one days," the Blackcaps cricketer told PTI last season.

Captains seek ball change

The BCCI last season allowed teams a one-ball change after the 10th over of the second innings to counter dew. On Wednesday, one captain proposed that teams

should be allowed to change the ball after the 10th over of the first innings.

"Ball change after 10 overs of first innings was proposed but it did not gain a lot of traction. There is heavy dew usually in the second innings and the current rule stands," said the source.

Training guidelines

The IPL captains, all Indians with Ishan Kishan leading SRH in place of regular skipper Pat Cummins, also inquired the IPL officials over training guidelines issued for the 2026 edition.

Saini comes in for Rana at KKR

KOLKATA: Pacer Navdeep Saini on Wednesday replaced Harshit Rana in the Kolkata Knight Riders squad for the IPL beginning on March 28.

Both Saini and Rana have played for India and represent Delhi in domestic cricket. Rana underwent a knee surgery last month that ruled him out of the T20 World Cup that India won.

"Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) and Gujarat Titans (GT) have picked Navdeep Saini and Kulwant Khejroliya respectively as player replacements for TATA Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026," said the IPL in a statement.

Khejroliya replaces Prithviraj Yarra in the Gujarat Titans squad.

Saini has scalped 23 wickets in 32 IPL matches played so far, in addition to 23 wickets in international cricket for India. He will join KKR for Rs 75 Lakh.

WOMEN'S COMPOUND TEAM SHINES

Archers claim two bronze, reach four finals in Asia Cup

BANGKOK: Indian archers bagged two bronze medals and also stormed into the finals of the men's recurve and women's compound team events on the second day of the Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1 here on Wednesday.

India also confirmed three medals in the individual section, but it came with the embarrassment for the recurve men, where none of the four archers could reach the medal rounds in a sharp fall from the previous edition's top-two finish by Vishnu Choudhary and Rahul.

The women's compound team improved on its bronze from the previous edition by reaching the final.

The trio of Chikitha Tani-parthi, Raj Kaur and Tejal Salve edged past local favourites Kanyavee Maneesombatkul, Kanoknapus Kaewchomphu and Chaniddapa Thanaratpitan 229-226 in a closely-fought semifinal to set up a summit clash against third-seeded Kazakhstan.

However, there was some disappointment in the men's compound section, where India fielded one of their most experienced combinations.

Despite topping the qualification round with Indian archers sweeping the top four



Juyel Sarkar, Rahul Banerjee, Sukhchain Singh and Devaang Gupta

spots, the team failed to defend its title and had to settle for a bronze.

The trio of Rajat Chauhan, Rishabh Yadav and Uday Kamboj squandered a strong five-point lead to lose 233-234 to Vietnam in the semifinals.

The Indians, however, bounced back to beat Bhutan 234-232 in the bronze medal match.

In the recurve section, India entered the men's team final with a 5-1 win over Malaysia. The top-seeded trio of Devaang Gupta, Sukhchain Singh and Juyel Sarkar won comfortably without dropping a set.

India took the opening set 53-50 and edged the second 53-52 in a low-scoring contest.

Later in the afternoon ses-

sion that catered to individual rounds, India had mixed outing.

In men's compound, Chauhan, Jawkar and Kamboj overcame the disappointment of team showing by progressing to the medal matches and kept alive hopes of a clean sweep.

Jawkar edged past Chauhan 149-148 in a tight semifinal, while Kamboj defeated local favourite Peerawat Rattanapongkiat 147-145.

Jawkar and Kamboj will now clash for gold, with Chauhan set to compete for bronze.

Ridhi kept India's campaign alive in women's recurve, storming into the final to stay in contention for her maiden individual gold.

NATIONAL INDOOR ATHLETICS CHAMPIONSHIPS

Gurindervir blazes to gold, Animesh disqualified

BHUBANESWAR: Ace Punjab sprinter Gurindervir Singh claimed the men's 60m gold in a national record time after pre-race favourite Animesh Kujur was disqualified in a dramatic final on the concluding day of the inaugural National Indoor Athletics Championships here on Wednesday.

In a fitting end to the two-day championships, the men's 60m final race lived up to the expectations, as Gurindervir,

Punjab sprinter clocked 6.60 seconds to better earlier national indoor best

who was representing Reliance Foundation and running his maiden indoor race, emerged as the fastest runner of the meet. The 25-year-old Gurindervir clocked 6.60 seconds to better the earlier national indoor best of 6.67 seconds which has been in

the name of Elakiya Dasan of Tamil Nadu since 2018.

The Athletics Federation of India (AFI), however, does not maintain an official list of national indoor records.

The race saw three false starts, with the third leading to local runner Animesh being

shown a red card, much to the stunned silence of the sizable crowd at the 17,000-seater, state-of-the-art indoor facility at the Kalinga Stadium complex.

Animesh, the national 100m and 200m outdoor national record holder, was seen speaking to the race officials before leaving the field of play disappointed. Lalu Prasad Bhoi of Odisha was second with 6.65 seconds while Nuzrat of Haryana was third.

Moment of truth for Italy as WC qualifiers begin

BERGAMO: When Fabio Cannavaro raised aloft the golden World Cup trophy inside Berlin's Olympic Stadium in 2006, few could have imagined the pain soccer's biggest event would inflict on Italy over the next two decades.

In 2010, the Azzurri put up a woeful title defence, not even winning a game in an embarrassing group-stage exit. In 2014, they again didn't reach the knockout stage, dumped out by a Uruguay goal scored soon after Luis Suarez bit Italy



Italy coach Gennaro Gattuso during a training session

defender Giorgio Chiellini.

As for the 2018 and 2022 tournaments, the Italians didn't even get there, eliminated in

the European playoffs in an utter humiliation for a soccer-mad nation.

No wonder the country is

on edge this week.

Italy are back in the World Cup playoffs, one of 16 European teams competing for the four remaining spots from the continent for this summer's tournament in the United States, Canada and Mexico.

Standing in Italy's way in the playoff semifinals taking place across Europe on Thursday will be Northern Ireland. Win that — and the Azzurri are big favorites — and they'll need to beat either Wales or Bosnia and Herzegovina.

सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएँ

भारत प्रगट कृपाला दीनदयाला कौसल्या हितकारी ।
हरषित महतारी मुनि मन हारी अद्भुत रूप बिचारी ॥

'I'VE ALWAYS BELIEVED IN HIGH-QUALITY WORK'

Bollywood actress Nimrat Kaur is known for films such as 'The Lunchbox' and 'Airlift'

Nimrat Kaur, known for films such as 'The Lunchbox' and 'Airlift', said in a world where everything is forgotten so quickly, her priority is to focus on consciously choosing roles that she hopes will linger in the collective memory of the audience.

"In a world where everything is forgotten so quickly, there's an overload of information and hence it's important to make choices that will last a little longer and stay in people's hearts for a long time. I've always believed in high-quality work and I try to stay close to stories that resonate with me," the actor told PTL.

"Also, just because one is free doesn't mean picking up another job for the sake of it, so unless I feel I really want to be part of something, that's when I say yes," she said, adding that she is eager to step into unexplored genres.

Kaur was talking on the sidelines of the recently concluded Lakme Fashion Week (LFW) x FDCI, where she walked the runway for designer label 'Jajaabor' by Kolkata-based Neelanjan Ghosh and his wife Kanika Sachdev.

The actress wore a gold floral corset with a knotted, draped skirt. She completed the look with a single-sleeved cutwork jacket and statement earrings.

Asked about her take on fashion, Kaur said it's a 'constant evolution'.

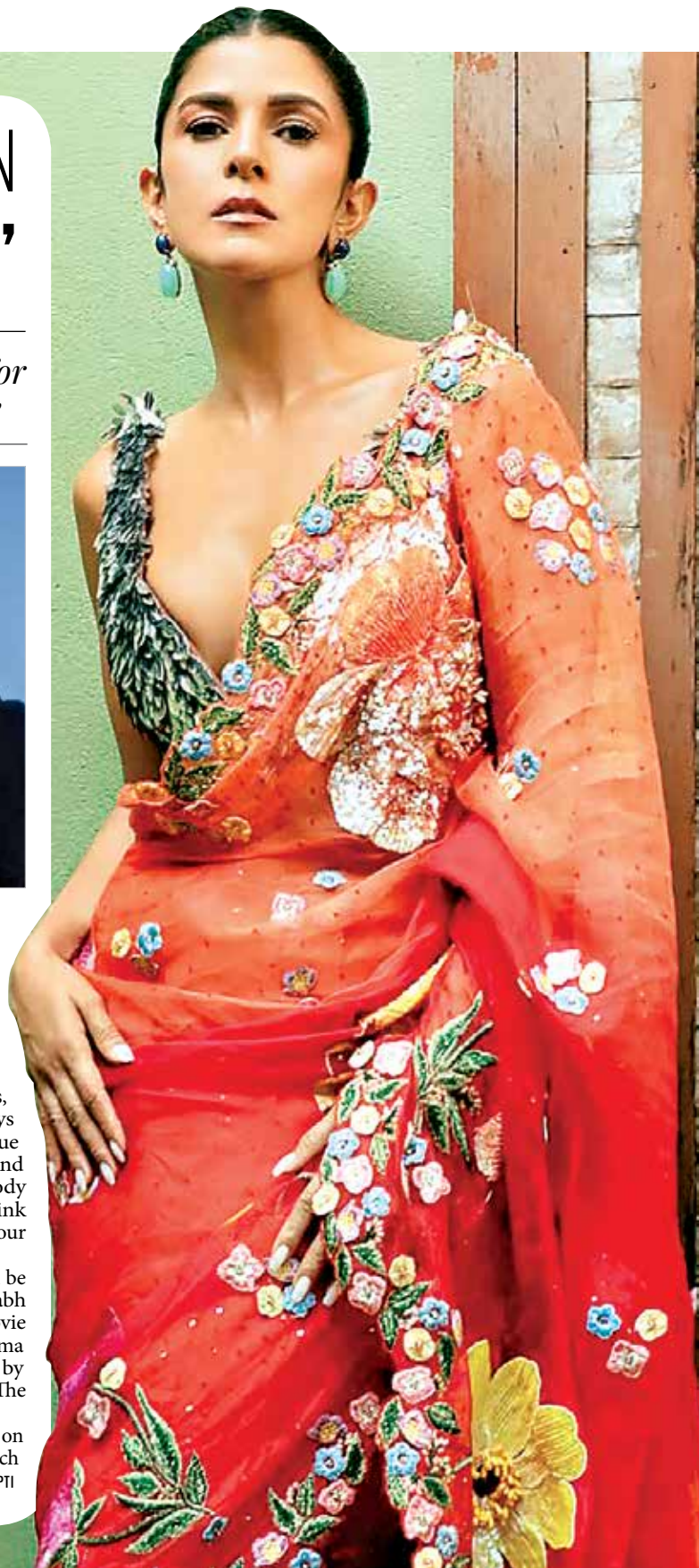


On the work front, she'll be seen alongside megastar Amitabh Bachchan in the upcoming movie 'Section 84'

"Fashion for me means constant evolution, experimenting, taking risks, but always staying true to who I am and keeping my body type in mind. I think that's when you truly channel your innermost confidence," she said.

On the work front, Kaur will be seen alongside megastar Amitabh Bachchan in the upcoming movie 'Section 84'. The courtroom drama thriller is written and directed by Ribhu Dasgupta of 'Te3n' and 'The Girl on the Trailer' fame.

'Lakme Fashion Week' started on March 19 and concluded on March 22 in Mumbai.



Arjun Rampal to star in 'BILLIONAIRE'

He will portray the character of a powerful business magnate in Amazon MX Player's series



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player set the stage buzzing at the 'Amazon Ads' event: Connected Worlds, as it pulled the curtain back on 'Billionaire', its upcoming original series, which will be headlined by Arjun Rampal. With ace filmmakers Hansal Mehta and Robbie Grewal at the helm, the series is written by Anubhav Chopra and Shantanu Sagara and produced by Prabhleen Sandhu, under the banner of 'Almighty Motion Picture'. The announcement marks a key step forward in the service's growing originals slate, reflecting its continued push towards engaging, premium storytelling that speaks to audiences across the country.

In a changing India, 'Billionaire' traces the rise of a powerful business magnate who rewrites the rules to build an empire of influ-

Ace filmmakers Hansal Mehta and Robbie Grewal will helm the upcoming series

ence and ambition. But when the very force that drives his success begins to consume everything around him, where does it all lead?

Speaking about the series, Amogh Dusat, Head of Content, 'Amazon MX Player', said, "'Billionaire' is a story about ambition, power and the cost of success. Unveiling the series at the 'Amazon Ads' event marks a significant milestone for us, setting the tone for the next phase of our originals journey. Collaborating with filmmakers like Hansal Mehta and Robbie Grewal brings strong creative depth and vision to

the project, while Arjun Rampal adds gravitas and intensity to this compelling character."

Sharing his excitement, Arjun Rampal added, "I am really excited about this one. Playing a role like this is definitely not something that comes your way every day and when it does, you grab it with both hands, feet and whatever you've got. Working with the incredible Hansal Mehta and Robbie Grewal has been a dream come true and I can't believe it's going to be fulfilled soon. It feels great to have the fabulous team at 'Amazon MX Player' making this journey even more special. The preparation starts soon, I am soaking into the world, getting to know the character better and really gearing up for something that will be a very rewarding journey. I can't wait for everyone to see what we have in store for the audiences."

Prime Video's 'Maa Ka Sum' set to be released on April 3

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video announced April 3 as the worldwide premiere date of its upcoming 'Prime Original' lighthearted drama 'Maa Ka Sum'. Directed by Nicholas Kharkongor and produced by Babita Ashwal under the banner of 'Eunoia Films', this heartwarming series celebrates the refreshing bond between a single mother and her 19-year-old son, built on friendship, mutual trust and the freedom to support each other as they grow together.

Written by Ravinder Randhawa and Sumrit Shahi, 'Maa Ka Sum' stars the versatile and talented Mona Singh, along with Mihir Ahuja, Angira Dhar and Ranveer Brar in lead roles.

'Maa Ka Sum' follows Agastya, a bright math prodigy in his late teens, played by Mihir Ahuja, who sees the world through graphs, numbers and algorithms. For him, every problem has a logical solution, even finding the perfect partner for his single mother, Vinita, portrayed by Mona Singh. Enter 'Project Mom: Equation ya Emotion?' But what begins as Agastya's carefully crafted plan soon turns into a quirky and heartwarming ride, where logic collides with real emotions, unexpected encounters and the unpredictability of life. With humour, warmth and a touch of math, 'Maa Ka Sum' offers a fresh and layered take on the mother-son dynamic.



This quirky storyline follows a 19-year-old math whiz out on a crucial mission, starring Mona Singh, Mihir Ahuja, Angira Dhar and Ranveer Brar in lead roles

"Stories rooted in relationships have a timeless appeal because they reflect emotions and bonds that feel deeply universal. At the heart of 'Maa Ka Sum' is a mother-son relationship portrayed with a rare freshness and emotional depth. This series captures the tenderness, friction and quiet understanding of this bond in an honest and deeply relatable way. Mona and Mihir are terrific in their roles. We are delighted to bring this story to our customers across the world on April 3," said Nikhil Madhok, Director & Head of Originals, 'Prime Video India'.

Emily Bader to feature in Netflix's '13 Going on 30' reboot



Emily Bader and Logan Lerman are set to feature in Netflix's reboot of the 2004 comedy film '13 Going on 30'.

According to the entertainment news outlet 'The Hollywood Reporter', the film will be directed by Brett Haley and will have a script by Hannah Markswich with revisions by Flora Greeson. The plot details of the film are kept under wraps.

The original film starred Jennifer Garner as Jenna Rink, alongside Mark Ruffalo. Directed by Gary Winick, the film revolved around Garner's 13-year-old character, who makes an unusual wish, just to wake up the next morning as a 30-year-old. Haley said '13 Going

The film will be directed by Brett Haley

on 30' is one of the rare and perfect films. "Funny, emotional, deeply human, with unforgettable performances from Jennifer Garner, Mark Ruffalo and Judy Greer. I'm a longtime fan, so stepping into this reimagining comes with tremendous responsibility. Jennifer Garner being on board as an executive producer, after playing such a big part of what made the original special, is especially meaningful," the director.

"I also couldn't be more excited to reunite with Emily Bader after 'People We Meet on Vacation'. She and Logan Lerman are a magical pairing," she added.

'Homebound' wins big at Critics' Choice Awards

On the web series front, Vikramaditya Motwane's crime thriller 'Black Warrant' dominated with four wins

Neeraj Ghaywan's 'Homebound' emerged as the biggest winner at the 8th Critics' Choice Awards, sweeping four major honours, including 'Best Film', 'Best Director', 'Best Actor' for Vishal Jethwa and 'Best Supporting Actress' for Shalini Vatsa.

The annual awards, presented by the Film Critics Guild in association with 'WPP Motion Entertainment', honour excellence across feature films, web series, short films and documentaries, with voting conducted by 56 film critics from across the country.

On the web series front, Vikramaditya Motwane's crime thriller 'Black Warrant' dominated with four wins - 'Best Web Series', 'Best Director', 'Best Supporting Actor' for Rahul Bhat and 'Best Writing' for Satyanshu Singh and Arkesh Ajay.

Priyanka Bose won 'Best Actress' in the feature film category for 'Agra', while Pasupathy claimed 'Best Supporting Actor' for 'Bison Kaalamadaan', his second Critics' Choice win.



Jaideep Ahlawat ('Paatal Lok' S2) and Monika Panwar ('Khauf') took home 'Best Actor' and 'Best Actress' honours

Jaideep Ahlawat ('Paatal Lok' Season 2) and Monika Panwar ('Khauf') took home the 'Best Actor' and 'Best Actress' honours respectively in the web series category, with Tillotama Shome winning 'Best Supporting Actress' for 'Paatal Lok' Season 2.

for 'Paatal Lok' Season 2.

Writing honours in the 'Feature Film' category went to Rohan Parashuram Kanawade for 'Sabar Bonda (Cactus Pears)', the Sundance-winning film that had received three nominations.

Cinematography and editing awards went to Sunil Borkar ('Jugnuma') and Chaman Chakko ('Lokah Chapter 1: Chandra'), respectively. The FCG Gender Sensitivity Award was presented to 'Sthal'.

In short films, filmmaker Apurva Bardapurkar's 'Maaybaapache Aashirwaad (Blessings)' led with three wins - 'Best Film', 'Best Director' and 'Best Writing'. Sunny Hinduja ('That's A Wrap') and Sheeba Chaddha ('Nighiyaan Chhavan') won acting honours in the category.

Vivek Chaudhary's 'I, Poppy', a 'Hot Docs' winner, claimed the 'Best Documentary' prize.



'Bridgerton' season five to focus on Francesca's story

The fifth season of the hit period drama 'Bridgerton' will put the spotlight on actress Hannah Dodd's Francesca Stirling, the introverted middle daughter of the Bridgerton family, 'Netflix' and 'Shondaland' announced.

The eight-episode season five of the Regency-era show has started production in the United Kingdom, the streamer said in a statement.

"Two years after losing her beloved husband, John, Fran decides to reenter the marriage mart for practical reasons. But



The fifth season is once again showrun by Jess Brownell

when John's cousin Michaela (Masali Baduza) returns to London to tend to the Kilmartin estate, Fran's complicated feel-

ings will have her questioning whether to stick to her pragmatic intentions or pursue her inner passions," read the official logline.

The fifth season is once again showrun by Jess Brownell. Shonda Rhimes, Betsy Beers, Tom Verica and Chris Van Dusen serve as executive producers.

Based on Julia Quinn's best-selling romance novels, 'Bridgerton' follows the eight Bridgerton siblings as they search for love during the social season in Regency-era England.

AROUND THE WORLD

» IIM Lucknow celebrates 40th convocation with 807 graduating students

» NIT Rourkela patents advanced system to detect intruders in restricted zones

» Students and faculty from over 35 nationalities come together to celebrate Multicultural Day at Canadian International School

» East Point Industry Leadership conclave calls for narrowing of industry-academia gap

BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHICH COUNTRY HAS THE WORLD'S LARGEST OIL RESERVES?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our March 19 edition question: **1900**

Correct answers were sent by: **Diksha Majumdar, Monodeep Ladia, Neel Ghosh**

NEWS & VIEWS

IIT Madras has established a Centre for Advanced Research on Spirituality, Science and Society to explore the intersection of spirituality, meditation, science, and society. It will contribute to global research on human well-being and consciousness and promote interdisciplinary research combining science, humanities, medicine, and architecture.

IIT Ropar's ANNAM.AI Centre of Excellence is all set to bring AI revolution to Indian agriculture with government collaborations. ANNAM.AI is building scalable agricultural AI intelligence technologies designed to make data-driven farming accessible across the country. Provided at no cost, these AI-based weather stations will deliver hyperlocal, real-time weather data to farmers.

LESS THAN 20% COLLEGES GET 75% PLACEMENTS IN 6 MONTHS: STUDY

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Despite employability becoming a central focus in India's higher education ecosystem through the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, only one in five institutions (16.67%) achieve over 75% placements within six months of graduation. The study by TeamLease Edtech reveals that while intent is strong, execution remains fragmented.

Soft skills training, widely recognized as essential for career readiness, remains absent in nearly half (49.39%) of institutions, with only 36% embedding them into curricula and just 15.75% offering continuous learning programs. This indicates that graduates are entering the workforce without critical communication and collaboration skills, weakening their job readiness.

Employer partnerships also lack depth, with fewer than 10% reporting very strong engagement and only 25% reporting strong or very strong partnerships. Alumni networks, another critical lever for mentorship and informal hiring pathways, remain underutilized, with 43.51% of institutions reporting no engagement at all. Institutions are failing to tap into one of the most accessible and cost-effective bridges to industry.

Applied learning is still nascent, with one in four institutions frequently integrating live industry projects into coursework. Discipline-wise adoption of employability practices shows uneven progress: Management (68.42%) and Engineering & Technology (60.53%) lead, while Commerce (54.39%), Science (53.51%), and Arts/Humanities (59.65%) lag behind. These statistics point to a fragmented system where employability readiness depends heavily on the discipline chosen, rather than a universal standard.



Trending COURSES

IIT MADRAS LAUNCHES MTECH & MA COURSES IN FRONTIER TECHNOLOGIES & GOVERNANCE

IIT Madras has announced the launch of several new postgraduate programmes, including an MA in Public Policy and multiple MTech programmes in emerging technology domains such as Semiconductor materials, Computational engineering in mechanical systems and Robotics.

These programmes have been designed to equip students with advanced interdisciplinary knowledge and skills required to address emerging challenges in governance, industry and technology.

KNOW MORE

» MA in Public Policy by Department of Humanities and Social Sciences

» MTech in Semiconductor Materials Technology by Department of Metallurgical and Materials Engineering

» MTech in Robotics by Department of Engineering Design

QS SUBJECT RANKINGS 2026: IIT BOMBAY, DELHI, MADRAS IN TOP 50

India added 20 new institutions this year, taking the total number of ranked universities to 99



of ranked universities to 99. The country has secured 27 top-50 positions across subjects and broad faculty areas, more than double the 12 recorded in 2024, which were achieved by 12 institutions.

Among Indian institutions, IIT Bombay leads with the highest number of subject entries, followed by IIT Kharagpur, University of Delhi, IIT Madras and IIT Delhi. Both IIT Bombay and IIT Delhi have secured positions within the global top 50, underscoring India's growing strength in digital and technology-driven disciplines. Notably, BITS Pilani has made a significant leap in Pharmacy and Pharmacology, rising from 84th to 45th place and entering the global top 50 for the first time.

IIT Delhi continues to be the country's top-ranked institution in the Engineering and Technology category, securing the 36th position globally. Core engineering disciplines have shown marked improvement in the QS Subject Rankings 2026. Electrical Engineering leads with a global rank of 36, followed by Mechanical Engineering (44), Computer Science (45), Chemical Engineering (48) and Civil Engineering (50). In contrast, only Electrical Engineering had featured in the top 50 in 2025, highlighting a significant year-on-year advancement across multiple subjects.

IIT DELHI CONTINUES TO BE THE TOP INDIAN INSTITUTE IN THE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGY CATEGORY WITH A GLOBAL RANK OF 36

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India's higher education sector has marked a significant global stride, with four IITs, Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) and BITS Pilani featuring among the world's top 50 institutions across various subjects in the latest QS World University

Rankings by Subject released on Wednesday. Compiled by London-based QS Quacquarelli Symonds, the rankings mark the 16th edition of this annual assessment. India has added 20 new institutions this year, taking its total tally

BEYOND CAMPUS



Guru Nanak Institute of Dental Sciences and Research (GNIDSR), a JIS Group educational initiative, introduced 'Dr Molar Bear', an engaging and educational character, to promote awareness about oral health and hygiene on the occasion of World Oral Health Day 2026. "Initiatives like Dr Molar Bear reflect the innovative spirit of our students and their commitment to community healthcare. By blending creativity with education, they have successfully conveyed an important message on oral hygiene in a manner that is both engaging and impactful," said JIS Group's Director Sardar Simarpreet Singh.

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